

Fate's Edge

Dhahara (The Kingdoms of Brass)

Viceroy's Scribe Govind
(keeper of the iron ledger, Sarvistan weigh-house)

June 3, 2026

Contents

Preface	ii
How to Use This Book	iii
A Note on Dhaharan Cultures	iv
1 Gateways & Travel	1
2 The Brass Coast	3
2.1 The Brass Coast — “The Shore of Silver and Spice”	5
3 The Nine Kingdomss	20
3.1 Dhahara: The Elephant Kingdoms and the Iron Passes	22
4 The Himadri Foothills	46
4.1 The Himadri Foothills — “The Roof of the World”	48
A Trade & Tariffs of Dhahara	61
B Elephants & Siege Engines	62
C The Ninth Seal and the Kalrantha Amulet	63
Epilogue	65
Colophon	66

Preface: The Iron Ledger

The mountain weighs every breath, every ingot, every oath. Pay in iron, pay in silence, or pay in blood. And when the ninth lease cracks, even the elephants will remember who fed them during the famine.

I am a viceroy's scribe – Dhaharan by birth, Aeler by employment. My grandfather kept the toll accounts at the Himadri passes; my mother balanced the grain quotas for the Brass Coast. I inherited an iron stamp and a healthy suspicion of anyone who does not seal their contracts with wax and a witness.

Dhahara is not a mystery. It is a negotiation – between the lowland kings and the Aeler viceroys, between the hill rajas and the Admiralty, between the elephant and the mahout. The Brass Coast runs on tariffs, not trust. The Nine Kingdomss measure power in elephant herds and marriage alliances. The Himadri foothills measure it in breaths – eight is safe, nine is the mountain's.

You will find no abstract “debt” here. You will find iron ingots stamped with a viceroy's mark, pepper auctions where a sneeze can cost a fortune, and a sealed mine where a demon whispers promises it cannot keep. Pay attention to the ninth clause. It is always the one that kills you.

The ledger is open. The scales are balanced. The ninth seal is warm.

— *Viceroy's Scribe Govind, Sarvistan weigh-house, stamped and witnessed*

How to Use This Book

This book is a companion to the *Fate's Edge Core Amaranthine Worldbook* and the *System Reference Document (SRD)*. It provides regional content for Dhahara – the Brass Coast, the Nine Kingdoms, and the Himadri Foothills – using the same card-driven generator system.

Each regional chapter contains:

- A short introduction (in the voice of Govind, who knows where the bodies are buried – literally).
- A local quote.
- An *almanac* – a quick Q&A about daily life in that region.
- Then the full generator tables ( *places*,  *people*,  *complications*,  *rewards*), imported from separate sources.

For the core rules (attributes, skills, actions, magic, summoning, travel, etc.), refer to the *Fate's Edge SRD or Player/GM Guides*. The generators assume you are familiar with Position, Effect, and Clocks.

“The road is a ledger – but only if you forget the elephants.” – Dusana of the Raven Road (apocryphal)

A Note on Dhaharan Cultures

Dhahara is a subcontinent of immense diversity – coastal spice ports, riverine kingdoms, highland iron mines, and steppe edges. The cultures presented here draw inspiration from South Asian history and geography, but they are not direct analogues. This note offers guidance for respectful portrayal.

Avoiding Monoliths

The Nine Kingdoms are not a single “India”. They are rival dynasties with distinct customs, languages, and patron deities. A queen of Vajrapur may be a devout follower of Mykriel; a king of Mahishmati may worship a local buffalo spirit. Show internal variety.

Agency, Not Exoticism

The Dhaharan rajas are not passive subjects of the Aeler viceroyalty. They negotiate, resist, and exploit the iron trade. The Sidhi diaspora on the Brass Coast are not helpless refugees – they run ropeways, lighthouse courts, and freedman’s seals. Let players see Dhaharan characters as competent, proud, and politically savvy.

Elephants as Partners, Not Props

War elephants are not dumb beasts. They have names, lineages, and mahouts who speak to them in a language of clicks and whistles. An elephant may remember a kindness for decades – and a betrayal longer.

The Ninth Seal

The demon in the Himadri mines is not a “dark god” caricature. It is a fragment of Varash the Unmaker, a being of cosmic indifference. It does not demand worship; it offers bargains. The horror is in the fine print.

GM Mantra

“Portray dignity, complexity, and the weight of a kept promise.”

Chapter 1

Gateways & Travel

The elephant remembers. The mountain forgets. The demon waits.

Travel Modes of Dhahara

Coast Roads (Brass Coast)

Tariffs, ropeways, and lighthouse courts. A **Lighthouse Charter** (Sidhi) or a **Customs Seal** (Admiralty) buys passage. Never board a ship with a green lantern at the mast – it means the captain is under a death vow.

River Routes (Nine Kingdomss)

The rivers of the Nine Kingdomss are borders and battlegrounds. A **Peacock Feather** or an **Iron Gate Pass** grants audience with a king. Never praise a king's elephant – compliment the mahout instead.

High Passes (Himadri Foothills)

Breath-counting, altitude sickness, and the Ninth Seal. A **Breath-Counter** or a **Toll Waiver** from the Aeler viceroy is required. Never count your breaths aloud in a mine – the mountain listens.

Elephant Caravans

The walking cities of Ngomebe are distant neighbours, but Dhaharan elephant caravans carry iron and spices along the **Salt Scar**. A **Keystone Shard** or a **Mason-Kin Hammer** may convince the Stone Men to share their path.

Gateways to Other Expansions

- **Amaranthine Core (Kahfagia, Ecktoria, etc.):** From the Brass Coast, the **Black River** leads north to Thepyrgos. From the Himadri passes, the **Aeler Underways** connect to the Spine.
- **Southern Realms (Oshiira, Ashaan, Ngomebe):** The Brass Coast is a direct sea route to Oshiira and Ashaan. The **Salt Scar** connects the Nine Kingdomss to Ngomebe's walking cities.
- **Way of Silk (Fhara, Sidhi, Pereshi, Kuvani, Tulkani):** The Brass Coast is home to a large Sidhi diaspora; lighthouse charters are accepted as credit. The Himadri passes lead to Pereshi highlands.
- **Eastern Realms (Sihai, Nihori, Ayokha):** Monsoon winds from the Brass Coast carry ships to Ayokha. The **Silk Road** east from the Nine Kingdomss leads to Sihai.

Chapter 2

The Brass Coast

Shore of Silver and Spice.

Govind says: “Three powers, one coast, and a tariff schedule that changes with the tide. The Admiralty holds the ports. The Sidhi run the ropeways. The rajas sharpen their swords in the hills. Choose a side – or let the coast choose for you.”

The Brass Coast is Dhahara’s southern rim: a humid, feverish coastline of palm groves, salt pans, and crowded port cities. Three powers bleed into each other here, and none can draw a clean breath. The Kahfagian Admiralty holds the ports and the tariff ledgers. The Sidhi diaspora runs the ropeways, the lighthouse courts, and the freedman’s seal. And the native Dhaharan rajas – the hill lords who have lived here since before any foreign flag flew – grow the pepper, mine the iron, and watch the coast from inland fortresses, waiting. The air smells of pepper, cinnamon, and the low tide of a thousand ships.

“Never board a ship that has a green lantern at the mast. It means the captain is under a death vow – and you are the payment.”

— Raja Govind of the Kalinga foothills

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice and fermented fish paste – the rice from coastal paddies, the fish caught by lighthouse keepers’ children. The children are paid in copper. The ninth child never takes payment. No one knows why.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a lighthouse code. The eight lamp-flashes: Tariff, Inspection, Quarantine, Smuggler, Pirate, Rescue, Home, and the ninth – the flash that means the collector is coming. The ninth flash is never used. It is a warning.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their papers. The Admiralty requires a manifest for every shipment. A stranger with perfect papers is a spy. The ninth page of every manifest is blank – that is where the dead travel.

What is the most common crime? Tariff evasion – but evasion is a profession. The tariffs are set by the Admiralty. The evaders pay the Admiralty directly. The payment is called a “consulting fee.” The ninth fee is always paid in salt, not silver.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The lighthouse lamps are not fuelled by oil. They are fuelled by the fat of the drowned – whales, sailors, slaves who

did not survive the crossing. The fat burns green. The ninth lamp on every tower is never lit. It is reserved for the collector.

Where do people go when they die? *To the sea. Weighted with brass and dropped in the deep channel called the Freedman's Grave. The ninth body dropped each year is never weighted. It always drifts toward the Admiral's palace.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a tariff – a payment of silver, calculated by the wronged party's estimate of their loss. The court takes a percentage. The ninth tariff ever collected was paid in a memory. The judge still remembers it.*

What is the most important festival? *The Burning of the Ledgers (new year). Every merchant's ledger is brought to the lighthouse. The ledgers are read aloud, then burned. The ash falls on the water. The ninth ledger is never burned – it is kept in a brass box at the bottom of the Freedman's Grave.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The lighthouse lamps are not all green. One lamp burns blue – the Admiral's personal beacon. The blue flame is a spirit – a Sidhi oracle bound to the lighthouse nine generations ago. Her ninth prophecy was never recorded. It said: "The collector will come by sea, and the ledger will burn from the bottom up."*

Integration Notes

The Brass Coast is a hub for the **Way of Silk** – Sidhi lighthouse charters are accepted as proof of credit from Fhara to Kuvani. Taharkan coffee arrives on monsoon winds, traded for brass and iron. Ayokhan spice merchants maintain warehouses here. And Sihai silk convoys offload at the same piers, paying tariffs to the Admiralty and bribes to the rajas.

2.1 The Brass Coast — “The Shore of Silver and Spice”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Three powers, one coast, and a memory written in salt. The wrong spark will burn the whole shore.*

Raja Govind (Native Hill Lord): “My grandfather watched the Kahfagians raise their first customs house on our beach. My father paid their tariffs. I will see them drown in their own ledgers — or I will drown trying. The Sidhi are guests. The Admiralty are thieves. The Brass Coast belongs to those who salt their own fish.”

Sidhi Freedman (Commoner): “My grandmother was born in Galanina. My mother was born in a slave ship. I was born in a lighthouse. The Admiralty calls me a subject. The Covenant calls me a freedman. But the rajas — they call me ‘guest’. And a guest who stays too long becomes a target.”

Genre / Mood: Mercantile noir, post-colonial pressure cooker, ghost-lit coast, three-way cold war.

Starting Location: A moonlit beach where three boats meet: a Kahfagian cutter, a Sidhi lighthouse skiff, and a Dhaharan spice dhow. A native pearl diver approaches you: “The Admiralty raised the salt tax again. The Sidhi say they’ll strike the ropeways. And my raja is sharpening his father’s sword. Pick a side — or the tide will pick for you.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Brass Coast is Dhahara's southern rim: a humid, feverish coastline of palm groves, salt pans, and crowded port cities. Three powers bleed into each other here, and none can draw a clean breath.

The Admiralty (Kahfagian) holds the warm-weather ports and the tariff schedules. Their warships patrol the shipping lanes, and their magistrates judge by maritime law. They call it a "client province." The locals call it a noose. The Admiralty is not evil — it is *hungry*. Its thalassocratic empire needs new markets, raw materials, and a captive shoreline to fuel its oligarchs' ever-growing appetites. The Brass Coast is a vein they intend to mine dry.

The Sidhi are a foreign diaspora — refugees from Galanina who fled the Ashaani slavers generations ago. They control the ropeways, the lighthouse courts, and the freedman's seal. They are welcome nowhere and trusted less, but without them the spice trade stops. Their story is one of forced migration: driven from their homeland, they moved from place to place, unwelcome at every stop, until at last they reached this coast. Like the Cajuns of another world, they made a new life from salt water and stubborn memory. They resent the rajas for the cold shoulders and the whispers — "foreigners," "drifters," "they keep to themselves." And they resent the Admiralty for trying to subjugate them all over again, trading chains of iron for chains of tariffs. The Sidhi are the economic engine of the region, but engines are the first thing conquerors seize.

The Native Dhaharan Rajas are the hill lords who have lived here since before the Admiralty's first anchor. They grow the pepper, mine the iron, and salt the fish. They watch the coast from inland fortresses, and they remember when no foreign flag flew over their beaches. Some accept bribes. Some sharpen blades. All of them are waiting. They resent the Admiralty for the slow colonisation — the tariffs, the land seizures, the quiet erasure of their courts. But they also resent the Sidhi. Centuries have passed, yet the Sidhi remain "outsiders" in the rajas' eyes — a people who keep to their own lighthouses, marry within their own circles, and speak a creole tongue that grates on the ear. The rajas envy the Sidhi's economic success: the ropeways, the trade networks, the freedman's seal that opens every port. They do not trust a people who have no homeland and yet have thrived. And that envy sharpens their knives. The air smells of pepper, cinnamon, and the low tide of a thousand ships. Here, a man can buy anything — a ship, a spice lot, a freedman's seal — and sell anything except his own shadow. But the price is never just silver. The Admiralty takes tariffs. The Sidhi take stories. The rajas take blood.

What you notice first: The heat pressing down like a damp cloth. The way the sea is the same colour as the sky, so the horizon disappears. The brass hooks on Sidhi belts, the brass scales on Admiralty desks, and the brass earrings in native chieftains' ears — three metals, one coast.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never board a ship that has a green lantern at the mast. It means the captain is under a death vow — and you are the payment. Also, never refuse a cup of palm wine offered by a raja's envoy. It is a test of honour, and the hills have long memories.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Tariff, The Heat of the Hills

The Brass Coast is not a colony — it is a slow-burning argument. The Admiralty holds the ports, the Sidhi hold the ropeways, and the rajas hold the land. Each side believes the other two are temporary. Each side is wrong.

The Admiralty's Powder Keg: The Kahfagian governor, Admiral Voss, rules from a whitewashed fort that was once a Sidhi stronghold. His marines drink coconut wine and mock the “lazy natives.” His clerks mint tariffs that change with the tide. But his ships are few, his garrison is underpaid, and the rajas have started hiring pirate dhows to intercept his grain convoys. The Admiralty needs new markets because its old ones are failing; the Brass Coast is meant to be the solution. Instead, it has become a wound that will not close.

The Sidhi's Fragile Web: The Sidhi run the ropeways, the lighthouse courts, and the freedman's seal. They are the only neutral party — and neutrality is a knife edge. A Sidhi strike would collapse the spice trade. A Sidhi betrayal would hand the coast to the Admiralty. And the rajas whisper that the Sidhi are just another foreign master, trading one chain for another. The Sidhi do not forget the long road that brought them here — the forced marches, the closed gates, the children buried in unnamed graves. They will not be pushed again. But the rajas' envy and the Admiralty's hunger leave them few roads out.

The Rajas' Slow Burn: The native Dhaharan hill lords speak a dozen dialects and worship a hundred spirits. They do not agree on much — except that the coast belongs to them. Some, like Raja Govind of the Kalinga foothills, play the Admiralty and the Sidhi against each other. Others, like the Veiled Queen of the Mangrove Delta, have already sent envoys to the Ashaani Breath-less. And in the smoky kitchens of every hill fort, young warriors sharpen their grandmother's steel and wait for the sign. They resent the Admiralty's taxes, yes — but they also resent the Sidhi's quiet prosperity. “They do not marry our daughters,” a raja's son might say. “They do not pray to our gods. They are strangers who have grown rich on our land.” That resentment is a fire the Admiralty fans when it suits them.

The green flame of the Sidhi lighthouses, the brass scales of the Admiralty, and the iron swords of the rajas — the Brass Coast is a tripwire. Any spark could set it ablaze.

The Three Powers: Faction Clocks

Use these clocks to track the coast's simmering tensions.

- **Admiralty Grip [6]:** Ticks up when the party enforces Kahfagian tariffs, sinks a pirate dhow, or exposes a Sidhi smuggler. At 4: Admiral Voss offers the party a Letter of Marque (legal piracy against rival powers). At 6: He declares martial law — all ports closed, all ships searched, all outsiders suspect.
- **Sidhi Ropeway Control [6]:** Ticks up when the party helps a Sidhi lighthouse keeper, frees a Sidhi prisoner, or protects a Sidhi caravan. At 4: The Sidhi offer a Lighthouse Charter (safe harbour in any Sidhi port). At 6: They call a ropeway strike — trade halts, and every faction blames each other.
- **Raja's Rebellion [8]:** Ticks up when the party smuggles weapons to the hills, assassinates an Admiralty official, or reveals a Sidhi secret. At 4: A raja sends a secret

envoy with a tiger's claw (an invitation to an alliance). At 8: The hills rise — native war parties raid coastal towns, and the Admiralty responds with fire ships.

These clocks are not mutually exclusive. A clever party might feed one to delay another — or light all three at once.

Prominent NPCs of the Brass Coast

|p0.22|p0.28|p0.3|p0.15|

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Voss	Kahfagian Governor	Maximise tariff revenue for the Admiralty	He keeps a record in his own blood; he says ink fades.
Syndic Olena	Port-master of Tamralipta (Sidhi)	Enforce the tariff schedule — but protect her people	Her brass hook is also a stamp; the stamp leaves a scar.
Raja Govind	Native hill lord of the Kalinga foothills	Break the Admiralty's monopoly — and the Sidhi's influence	He has never seen the sea. He is afraid of it, but he will never admit that.
The Veiled Queen	Native ruler of the mangrove delta (matriarch)	Keep her people free by playing all sides against each other	She wears a mask of hammered silver; no one has seen her face in twenty years.
Captain Idris	Sidhi lighthouse commander	Keep the Brass Coast free of Ashaani slavers — and his people alive	His left eye is a brass lens; he can read the stars even in fog.
Shipwright Dara	Builder of freedmen's boats (Sidhi)	Launch one new vessel each year for escaped slaves	She names each boat after a dead family member. The names are never painted — only carved.
The Black Bishop	Covenant Maritime Judge	Enforce the law — but his conscience is a rusty nail	He wears a ring made from a freed slaver's ship nail. The nail still has rust on it.
Rani Kumar (Young Firebrand)	Raja Govind's daughter, leader of the hill youth	Drive the foreigners into the sea — by any means	She has a tattoo of a coiled tiger on her right arm. It moves when she is angry.

Names of the Brass Coast

Native Dhaharan names dominate (Tamil, Sinhalese, Malayali influences). Sidhi names (Levantine/coastal) are marked with an asterisk. Kahfagian names are rare among locals.

|p0.25|p0.25|p0.2|p0.2|

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surname/Clan	Epithets
Govind	Olena*	Pallava	<i>the Brass-Fingered</i>

Kannan Dara* Chettiar *Coin-Counter*

Muthu Mangai Saliya *the Tide-Reader*

Rajendran Ilavarasi Pattinam *Lighthouse Born**

Senthil Kalyani Mudaliar *Shark-Tooth*

Anjali* Kumar (surname) Vellalar *the Unbent*

(**Harbour / Hill Fort / Lighthouse**) Tamralipta harbour (a forest of masts); Raja Govind's hill fort (laterite stone, painted with tigers); Sidhi lighthouse with a brass mirror and green flame.

Spades — Places

*Native sites are marked with ‡; Sidhi sites with *; Admiralty sites with †.*

2. **Tamralipta Harbour*‡** — A forest of masts; the smell of tar and spices. *The harbour is a maze of floating houses. The residents are all Sidhi. They never touch the shore — but they pay taxes to the Admiralty.* '[TRADE]'
3. **Pepper Warehouse (Native-owned)†** — A long building with slatted walls; the air is sharp. *The workers are freedmen earning passage for their families. Their eyes are red from pepper dust. They never blink. The owner is a raja's cousin.* '[LABOR]'
4. **Lighthouse of the Brass Flame*** — A stone tower with a copper mirror. *The light is green. It shows the faces of the drowned. The keeper knows their names — and some of them are still walking.* '[JUSTICE]'
5. **Salt Pan of the Silent Widows†** — A flat expanse of white crust; women in black work the rakes. *The women are all widows; their husbands were lost at sea — to storms, to slavers, to Admiralty press gangs. The salt is bitter. They sell it to remember.* '[COMMUNITY]'
6. **Kahfagian Admiralty House‡** — A white building with a veranda; a flag with a lantern. *The flag is lowered at sunset. The Admiral is drunk by dawn. The clerks are sober — and watching. Native servants spit in the coffee.* '[AUTHORITY]'
7. **Sidhi Court of the Lighthouse*** — A circular chamber with a brass scale. *The judge is blind; she hears truth in the echo of a coin. The coin is never returned. The rajas send observers, but they never speak.* '[JUSTICE]'
8. **Palm Grove of the Elephants†** — A grove where temple elephants are bathed. *The elephants are painted with turmeric. The paint is a prayer for safe passage — and for the foreigners to leave.* '[RITUAL]'

9. **Coral Reef of the Sunken Ship (Neutral)** — A reef just offshore; a mast breaks the surface. *The ship was a slaver; the slaves escaped. They live in the reef now. They trade salvage for silence — and they remember which raja helped them.* ‘[LEGEND]’
10. **Pepper Auction Floor (Native-owned)†** — A crowded hall; voices bid in claps. *The auctioneer has a hammer of whalebone. It cracks when he lies. The cracks are getting louder. The Admiralty’s tariff agents sit in a raised gallery.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **The Green Lantern Tavern (Sidhi)*** — A low building with a green lantern. *The lantern is never lit. The owner says it would attract the wrong kind of dead. The right kind drink here for free — and they remember every whispered plot.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **The Shipbreaker’s Yard (Admiralty-licensed)‡** — A beach where old ships are dismantled. *The workers are convicts; they wear chains that drag in the sand. They earn one link off each season. The chains are paid for by the rajas’ taxes.* ‘[LABOR]’
- K **The Admiral’s Palace (Former Sidhi Fort)‡** — A former Sidhi fort, now occupied by Kahfagian officers. *The flag is flown upside down. The Admiral does not know the difference. The Sidhi do. They count the days. The rajas count the cannons.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **The Undercliff (Smuggler’s Cove, native-controlled)†** — A smuggler’s cove accessible only at low tide. *The entrance is a cave; the cave leads to a hidden harbour. The harbour is a city of thieves — and a union of freedmen. The rajas’ tax collectors meet here to plan.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Rani Kumar (Native Firebrand)†** — Raja Govind’s daughter, with a tiger coiled on her arm. *“My father negotiates. I sharpen swords. The Admiralty will leave — or they will be buried here. There is no third way.”* ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[REBELLION]’
3. **Sidhi Lighthouse Keeper*** — Blind in one eye; carries a brass telescope. He can see the future through the lens. *“Only the futures that end at sea,” he says. “The rest are private. I sell them to captains who need to avoid them — and to rajas who need to know when to strike.”* ‘[JUSTICE]’
4. **Kahfagian Port-Master (Syndic Olena)‡** — A thin woman with a brass hook for a hand. The hook is a stamp. *She stamps every tariff receipt. The stamp leaves a scar. She says it builds character. The scarred merchants say it builds grudges.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Pepper Factor (Native)†** — A thin woman with red-stained fingers and a black tongue. She is the raja’s eyes in the market. *She can tell the quality of pepper by taste. She has never been wrong. She has also never been paid on time — by the Admiralty.* ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[SPY]’

6. **Shipwright Dara (Sidhi)*** — A woman with a hammer and a jar of brass nails. She builds boats for freed slaves. *Each boat is named after a dead family member. The names are never painted — only carved. The wood remembers. So do the rajas, who buy her boats for their own smugglers.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
7. **Admiral Voss‡** — A grey-haired man with a glass eye. The glass eye is from a defeated pirate. *The pirate still watches through it. Voss does not sleep well. The eye weeps salt water. He dreams of the rajas’ torches.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Raja Govind (Inland Hill Lord)†** — A young man in silk, come to the coast to sell iron. He has never seen the sea. *He is afraid of it. He refuses to step on a boat. He negotiates from the shore, shouting through a brass horn. His daughter mocks him — but she will not leave his side.* ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[TRAGEDY]’
9. **The Veiled Queen (Mangrove Delta)†** — A woman in a silver mask, ruler of the southern marshes. *“I have spoken to the Admiralty’s spy, the Sidhi’s whisperer, and the Ashaani’s shadow. All of them will pay for my people’s freedom — or I will drown them all in the delta. The mask is not to hide my face. It is to hide my smile.”* ‘[MYSTERY]’ ‘[MASTERMIND]’
10. **Smuggler Captain (Neutral, works for highest bidder)** — A woman with a parrot on her shoulder, a curved knife on her belt. *The parrot is her navigator; it knows the reefs by sound. The parrot is blind. It has never been wrong. Her loyalty is to the cargo’s weight, not any flag.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- J **The Black Bishop (Covenant Maritime Judge)** — A judge who rules on maritime disputes. He wears a ring made from a ship’s nail. *The ship was the first slaver he freed. The nail still has rust on it. He calls it his conscience. The Admiralty calls him a fool. The rajas call him a useful idiot.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- Q **The Green Lantern’s Owner (Sidhi widow)*** — A woman with no shadow. She sold her shadow for the tavern. *The shadow now serves drinks. The customers do not notice. The shadow remembers every secret — and whispers them to the highest bidder.* ‘[MYSTERY]’
- K **The Sea King of Kalinga (Pirate Lord, hired by rajas)†** — A pirate lord with a fleet of painted dhows. *He has nine wives; each is from a different kingdom. The ninth is a spy. He knows. He keeps her for the gossip — and because she is the only one who knows the delta’s secret channels.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[PIRATE]’
- A **The First Freedman (Legend, Sidhi)*** — A slave who bought his freedom with a story. He now sits at the bottom of the Ninth Well. *If you tell him a true story, he will tell you the location of a hidden lighthouse. The lighthouse is not on any map. It is where the rajas and the Sidhi first swore a secret pact.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Pepper Dust Fire (Warehouse)†** — A spark ignites a native-owned warehouse; the air is flammable. '[DISASTER]' *The workers are trapped. Save them or save the cargo. The fire was set by an Admiralty agent to frame the Sidhi. The rajas are watching.*
3. **Admiralty Press Gang‡** — Kahfagian marines grab bystanders for the fleet. '[AUTHORITY]' '[COMBAT]' *The marines are drunk. They do not recognise rank. One of the bystanders is a raja's son in disguise. The hills will demand blood if he is taken.*
4. **Green Lantern Lit (Sidhi Tavern)*** — Someone lights the forbidden lantern. The dead come. '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]' *They are looking for the person who killed them. That person is a native tax collector who sold out his village. The crowd will tear him apart — or protect him. Choose.*
5. **Shipbreaker's Curse (Admiralty Yard)‡** — A cursed ship in the yard breaks its chains. It wants a new victim — a ship's captain. '[DEATH]' '[COMBAT]' *The captain is an Admiralty loyalist. The ship was a slaver that carried native prisoners. The ghosts want his blood. Do you help him or let them take him?*
6. **Tariff Hike (Admiralty Decree)‡** — The port-master doubles duties on all goods. The hike is a bribe. '[AUTHORITY]' '[WEIGHT]' *The bribe is to the Black Bishop. The Bishop has already accepted. Your protest is treason. The native merchants are watching to see which side you choose.*
7. **Coral Reef Piracy (Native-hired)†** — Pirates hide behind the reef; they attack at dusk. '[COMBAT]' '[STEALTH]' *The pirates are hired by a raja to disrupt Admiralty supply ships. They will not harm Sidhi vessels — but they cannot always tell the difference.*
8. **Elephant Rampage (Native Temple)†** — A temple elephant breaks free and runs through the market. '[DISASTER]' *It is looking for its mahout, who was arrested by the Admiralty for smuggling. The mahout is innocent. The elephant will not hurt children. Admiralty marines are another matter.*
9. **Smuggler's Betrayal (Neutral)** — A smuggler captain sells the party to the Admiralty. '[SOCIAL]' '[TRAP]' *The betrayal was a test. The captain wants to see if you can escape. If you do, you are worthy of trust — and the rajas will contact you.*
10. **Sea King's Tax (Pirate Blockade, hired by rajas)†** — A Kalingan pirate fleet blockades the harbour. The tax is one ship. '[AUTHORITY]' '[COMBAT]' *Choose which ship to give up. The Sea King will remember your choice. The crew will remember longer. The rajas are testing your loyalty.*
- J Drowned Priest's Demand (Neutral)** — The ghost appears during the day. He asks for a name. '[DEATH]' '[SOCIAL]' *The name must be someone who owes*

a death — a slaver, a corrupt customs officer, a raja who sold his own people. If you cannot give one, he takes yours.

- Q Black Bishop's Verdict (False)‡** — The judge declares the party's cargo forfeit. The verdict is false. '[JUSTICE]' '[TRAP]' *The bishop is bribed. The briber is the Admiralty. Prove it, or lose everything. The real verdict is written in disappearing ink. The rajas' spies are in the gallery.*
- K Sea King's Ninth Wife (Spy, works for the Veiled Queen)†** — The spy reveals herself. She offers a deal: the Sea King's treasure for safe passage. '[POLITICS]' '[MAGIC]' *The treasure is a curse. The curse is a fragment of the Kalrantha amulet. The amulet whispers in your sleep. It tells you which faction will betray you first.*
- A Undercliff Collapse (Smuggler's Cove)†** — A rockslide seals the smugglers' cove. Inside are the party and a monster. '[DEATH]' '[TRAP]' *The monster is a salt-crocodile. It is blind. It hunts by sound. The walls are listening — and so are the rajas' spies, who will arrive at dawn to see who survived.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Lighthouse Charter (Sidhi)*** — The right to anchor in any Sidhi port without inspection. '[TRAVEL]' *The key fits a lock on a sea-chest, not a harbour gate. The chest contains a map of smuggler's coves — and the names of rajas who pay protection.*
3. **Lighthouse Keeper's Lens (Sidhi)*** — Look through it to see the nearest slaver ship. '[JUSTICE]' *The lens also shows the faces of the slaves on board. They look back. They do not blink. It also shows the brand on the slaver's captain — and which raja sold them.*
4. **Freedman's Seal (Sidhi)*** — Proof of emancipation. Glows when a slaver ship is near. '[SOCIAL]' *It also glows when a Black Hand agent is near — and when a native informer is in the room. Trust the glow. It has never been wrong.*
5. **Pepper Merchant's Seal (Native)†** — A wax seal from a dead factor. Present it to sell pepper at double price. '[TRADE]' *The factor's ghost haunts the warehouse. He will ask for a story. The story must be about a bad deal — preferably one that cheated the Admiralty.*
6. **Salt Widow's Blessing (Native)†** — A bag of bitter salt. Throw it into the sea to calm a storm. '[WEATHER]' *The salt is from the widows' pans. They have blessed it with their tears. The storm will pause for one hour — long enough for a raja's fleet to escape.*
7. **Admiral's Pardon (Kahfagian)‡** — A signed document. Cancels one crime on the Brass Coast. '[AUTHORITY]' *The Admiral signs with a glass eye. The signature is*

a lie. The pardon still works — but the eye watches you afterwards. It reports to the Admiralty's spymaster.

8. **Sidhi Court Ruling (Sidhi)*** — A written judgment. Win any maritime dispute in a Sidhi court. '[JUSTICE]' *The ruling is valid only if witnessed by a lighthouse keeper. The keeper is Idris. He will witness for a story — and the story will reach the rajas within a day.*
9. **Elephant's Tooth (Native)†** — A tusk from a temple elephant. Present it to any temple for shelter. '[SOCIAL]' *The elephant was executed for killing an Admiralty tax collector. The temple will not refuse. They will also not ask questions. They will offer you a cup of palm wine — and a message from the Veiled Queen.*
10. **Shipbreaker's Hook (Admiralty)‡** — The hook of a dead shipbreaker. Use it to command the cursed ship in the yard. '[MAGIC]' *The ship will obey one command — then it will try to drown you. The hook is warm. It remembers its owner's last words: "Burn the tariff ledgers."*
- J **Smuggler's Map (Neutral)** — A chart of hidden coves, tattooed on a dead sailor's back. '[TRAVEL]' *The skin is preserved in salt water. It must be kept wet or the map fades. The sailor's ghost will guide you — for a fee. The fee is a promise to avenge him against the Admiralty.*
- Q **Sea King's Pardon (Native-hired)†** — A flag of truce. Fly it to pass Kalingan waters unharmed. '[TRAVEL]' *The flag is a shirt. The shirt belonged to a dead pirate — a native hero who fought the Admiralty. He may want it back. He will ask politely. If you refuse, the rajas will remember.*
- K **Green Lantern's Flame (Sidhi)*** — A small lantern that burns green. Light it to summon the dead. '[DEATH]' *They will answer one question. Then they will ask one. The question is never easy. The answer is never free — but the dead know which faction is lying.*
- A **Black Bishop's Ring (Covenant)** — Wear it to be immune to Admiralty arrest in Sidhi ports. '[JUSTICE]' *The nail is from a freed slaver. The slaves' ghosts protect you. They also watch. They judge. They remember. If you betray the rajas, the ring will grow cold — and the ghosts will abandon you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, lenses, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **coast-omens**—green flames that burn blue, salt that tastes sweet, a drowned face in a still puddle, a tiger’s roar from the hills.
- When a Club is drawn, tick one of the three faction clocks (Admiralty Grip, Sidhi Ropeway Control, Raja’s Rebellion) based on the nature of the complication.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Three Faction Clocks (see above).** These are the campaign’s pressure gauge. Use them to determine which faction acts first when the party dithers.
- **The Sidhi Diaspora Network:** Sidhi characters gain +1 die on social rolls with other Sidhi, but –1 die on social rolls with Admiralty officials. With native rajas, they are neutral (no modifier) — but the rajas will always treat them as “guests,” never as allies.
- **Native Hill Networks:** Native characters gain +1 die on social rolls with rajas and hill folk, but –1 die on social rolls with Admiralty officials. With Sidhi, they are cautious (no modifier) — the Sidhi are useful, but they are still foreigners.
- **The Tariff Clock [6] (renamed Admiralty Grip).** Already covered above.
- **Green Flame Justice:** Sidhi lighthouse courts operate on the principle of “witnessed truth.” Any party member may request a green flame judgment instead of a conventional trial. Roll Presence + Lore (DV 4). On success, the judge rules in your favour; on a miss, the green flame shows a hidden crime you committed — and the penalty is doubled. However, if the crime was committed against a native, the rajas will learn of it.
- **Ropeway Leverage:** The ropeways are the arteries of the coast. A character who controls a ropeway (by owning a share, bribing a foreman, or holding a Sidhi charter) may impose a “ropeway toll” on any cargo moving through that district: +1 Supply to the party or –1 Supply to a rival. Using this leverage ticks the Sidhi Ropeway Control clock by 1.
- **Native Smuggling Routes:** A character with a native contact (e.g., a pepper factor or a salt widow) can use native smuggling routes to move goods without Admiralty inspection. This ticks the Raja’s Rebellion clock by 1 but also ticks the Tariff Clock (Admiralty Grip) by 1 if discovered.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Green Keeper** — The Witness. *The flame that shows the truth, even when it burns — especially when it burns a foreigner’s lie.*
 - **The Hook** — Maelstraeus. *The price of a second chance; the weight on a freed-man’s soul. The rajas say the Hook is Admiralty silver.*

- **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the toll that the sea collects. The widows say he is a native god, stolen by the Sidhi.*
- **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost rebellions. The Veiled Queen invokes him before every raid.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Sidhi Freedmen and the Breath-less (Ashaan):** The Sidhi of the Brass Coast have family who were taken as slaves to Ashan. A freedman's seal can be used to smuggle a Breath-less agent out of Galanina. Captain Idris has done this nine times. The tenth may be his last — and the rajas are watching to see if the Sidhi are still loyal to their own.
- **Spice Trade and the Fhara (Way of Silk):** Pepper from the Brass Coast is a major commodity on the Fhara caravan routes. A Fhara well-judge may accept a Sidhi lighthouse charter as proof of credit. The charter must be witnessed by a living flame. The rajas have begun forging their own charters — and the Fhara cannot tell the difference.
- **The Undercliff and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The smuggler's cove is a known transit point for artifacts stolen from the Himadri temple. The Sea King's ninth wife claims to have seen the amulet pass through. She also claims the amulet spoke to her. It asked for a drink of water. The Veiled Queen believes the amulet is the key to driving out the Admiralty — but only if she can control it.
- **The Drowned Priest and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The ghost who walks the shore at low tide is said to be a Oath-Keeper who lost his way. Aelaerem leave offerings of salt to keep him from following them home. The salt must be from the pans of the Silent Widows. Any other salt will attract him — and the rajas have started using him as a weapon, luring him toward Admiralty patrols.
- **The Green Flame and the Dreamer (Ikasha):** The Sidhi lighthouse lamps burn green — the colour of a promise kept, a debt paid, a memory not yet drowned. Some Breath-less agents whisper that the first green flame was lit from a coal stolen from the Dreamer's brazier, before Ikasha was sealed. The Sidhi do not confirm this. They do not deny it. They only tend the flame and ask no questions.
- **The Serpent's Judgment (Isoka) at the Freedman's Seal:** When a Sidhi freedman receives their brass seal, they are made to cut a thread in the presence of a lighthouse keeper. The thread represents the slaver's claim. If the cut is clean, the freedman is declared unbound. If the thread frays, the keeper demands a name — the name of the slaver who still holds a memory of them. This ritual is older than the Covenant. Some say it was taught by the Serpent herself, before she turned away from Ashaan.
- **The Raven's Shadow on the Ropeways:** At low tide, when the brass lanterns gutter, a shadow sometimes passes over the ropeways — a shadow with the shape of a

bird, though no bird flies at night. The Sidhi workers touch their freedman's seals and whisper a single word: "Remember." They do not say whose shadow it is. The Brass Coast rajas say it is Ikasha's dream, still looking for a shore. The Admiralty calls it a trick of the light. The Sidhi know better.

Brass Coast Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Toss a crust into the harbour. Ignore the first *Pepper Dust Fire* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Anchor Chain:** Tie a sailor's knot in a mooring rope. Cancel *Admiralty Press Gang* or take -1 die on your next escape roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Lighthouse:** Whisper a dead captain's name into the green flame. Gain +1 Effect when smuggling this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sidhi — and the rajas will learn the name. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Tiger's Whistle:** Whistle three times toward the hills before a deal. If a tiger answers, the deal is honest. If silent, the other party is lying. (GM spends 1 SB to have a tiger answer falsely once per session.) '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Admiralty customs, Sidhi ropemen, or a raja's spy.**
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **warehouse guards, lighthouse keepers, or hill lookouts.**
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **smugglers, the Black Bishop's agents, or a tiger.**
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide.**
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock.**

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Admiralty marines, Sidhi enforcers, or a raja's war party** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **green flash, rising tide, or a dust storm from the hills.**
- **Foe Appears:** An **Admiralty press gang, a Sidhi claim-keeper, or a native elephant** arrives on scene.

- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Admiralty cutters, Sidhi ropemen, or hill warriors** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**tariff hike declared / green lantern lit / raja’s rebellion begins early**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment (Admiralty Grip, Sidhi Ropeway Control, or Raja’s Rebellion).
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Admiral Voss, the Veiled Queen, or the Black Bishop** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**harbour catches fire / lighthouse collapses / hill fort’s beacon is lit**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives — often by revealing that a faction has already made a secret pact.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Brass Coast (Tariff Law):** Scales tip without weight, schedules rewrite themselves, a port-master’s hook stamps a nullity — and a raja’s dagger appears on the counter.
- **Brass Coast (Lighthouse Law):** Green flame flickers, salt crystals form on skin, a drowned face appears in a puddle — and a hill lookout’s horn sounds twice.
- **Brass Coast (Smuggler’s Law):** Ropeways hum with whispers, a parrot speaks a secret, a hidden cove appears on no map — and a tiger’s shadow crosses the moon.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Sail):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Green Flash* (the lighthouse blinds pursuers).
- **Cut the Tariff (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a lighthouse charter is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Raid (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Admiralty Press Gang*, you pick who is taken; on a miss, the GM does — and the rajas will remember who you abandoned.

Boss Seeds (Tariff & Flame & Rebellion)

- **The Hook-Master (Admiralty Spymaster)‡** — *Phases:* Tariff Forgeries → Orchestrated Strike → Port Coup. *Cracks:* recover a true stamp, expose a forged schedule, survive a night in a lighthouse — or turn a raja against him.
- **The Drowned Admiral (Ghost Fleet, Sidhi legend)*** — *Phases:* Lost Ships Called Home → Procession of Empty Lanterns → Tide-Baptism of a Factor. *Cracks:* relic green flame, survivor testimony, the lighthouse keeper’s lens turning clear — and a native prayer spoken over the drowned.
- **The Veiled Queen’s Ascension (Native Rebellion)†** — *Phases:* Whisper in the Mangroves → The Tiger’s Claw → The Burning of the Schedules. *Cracks:* unmask her face (revealing a childhood scar), expose her alliance with the Ashaani, or convince her that freedom requires mercy, not just blood.

Patronage & Power

On the Brass Coast, power flows through tariffs, ropeways, and the loyalty of the hill folk. The Admiralty holds the ports, the Sidhi hold the ropes, and the rajas hold the land. No single faction can win — but any faction can light the fuse.

For the GM: Use the three faction clocks as your campaign’s heartbeat. Every session, tick at least one clock based on the party’s actions (or inaction). Let the players see the powder keg growing. When a clock fills, something explodes — a rebellion, a strike, a massacre. The party’s job is not to prevent the explosion — it’s to survive it and choose who rises from the ashes.

Native Focus: The rajas are not victims — they are players. They have their own spies, their own fleets (via the Sea King), and their own magical traditions (tiger spirits, salt widows, elephant oracles). Whenever the party interacts with the Brass Coast, ask: “How would a native see this?” The Sidhi are refugees; the Admiralty are occupiers. The rajas are the hosts — and they are tired of guests.

Chapter 3

The Nine Kingdomss

The Peacock Throne and Its Rivals.

Govind sighs: *“The number nine is a lie. There have never been nine kingdoms. The number is a prayer – a hope that the Hollow will not notice that one is always missing. The throne weeps because the missing kingdom is always the one that mattered.”*

Between the Satrapies plateau and the Brass Coast lies a fertile, contested lowland: the land of the Nine Kingdomss, the heart of Dhahara. Here, ancient dynasties still claim descent from the sun, and the Peacock Throne of Ahimsa casts its shadow over half a dozen rival courts. Rivers are borders; elephants are war machines; every harvest is a negotiation between kings who have never met but whose grandfathers swore blood oaths. The Covenant has a strong presence in the sacred cities; the Aeler have counting houses in the iron towns; the Sidhi sail up the rivers to trade. But Dhahara belongs to the Dhaharan – to their poets, their temple dancers, their bandit kings, and their queens who rule from behind silk screens.

“Never praise a king’s elephant. The elephant is sacred; your praise will be taken as an insult to the king’s own mount. Compliment the mahout instead. The mahout will tell the elephant.”

— Temple Dancer Mira

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge with mango pickle – the rice from the royal granaries, the mangoes from the king’s orchards. The ninth grain of rice in every bowl is left uneaten. It is an offering to the missing kingdom.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their genealogy. Nine Kingdomss children learn the names of their ancestors back to the sun. The ninth ancestor is never named. That is the gap where the Hollow sits.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their caste mark. The nine castes – priest, warrior, merchant, farmer, artisan, servant, outcast, foreigner, and the ninth – the caste that has no name. The ninth caste is the king’s spies. Their faces are always the same. No one can describe them.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasion – a political statement. The king’s tax collectors are also his spies. The ninth tax collector vanished last year. His shadow still walks the counting house.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Peacock Throne is empty. The Maharaja died seven years ago. The courtiers rule in his name. The ninth minister is a eunuch who controls the palace guards. He has no shadow.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the river. Cremated on the ghats, ashes scattered on the water. The ninth ghat is reserved for the missing kingdom. It has never been used. It is always warm.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a dance – a performance at the temple of the sun. If the priest smiles, you are forgiven. If the priest weeps, you are not. If the priest is silent, you are cursed. The ninth dance ever performed was for a debt to the Hollow. The dancer is still dancing.*

What is the most important festival? *The Coronation of the Monsoon (summer). The king offers a golden elephant to the rain clouds. The clouds have refused for nine years. The ninth golden elephant was hollow. It was filled with the ashes of the ninth king.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The golden elephant is hollow. It is filled with the ashes of the ninth king – the one who tried to unite the kingdoms and failed. His ghost rides the monsoon winds. He is still trying.*

Integration Notes

The Nine Kingdomss are a crossroads for the **Way of Silk** – Tulkani caravans pass through, trading story-knots for elephant ivory. Taharkan coffee is a favourite of the Maharaja's court. Sihai silk is measured against Aeler iron in the counting houses of Vajrapur. And the Kalrantha amulet – a fragment of the demon Varash – is said to be hidden somewhere in the ruins of Rajagriha, sought by thieves and Veiled Sisters alike.

3.1 Dhahara: The Elephant Kingdoms and the Iron Passes

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The elephant remembers every path. The mountain counts every breath. The peacock watches the ninth throne.*

Maharaja of Ahimsa (Elite): “The Peacock Throne is not a seat. It is a promise made by the first sun king: that the nine kingdoms would remain nine, never one, never fewer. I do not rule. I balance. A peacock’s tail has nine eyes. Each eye watches a different kingdom. When one closes, the throne weeps. The Aeler in the high passes are not our masters. They are our debtors. The mountain remembers who first carved the tunnels.”

Viceroy Thrain (Aeler Elite): “The passes do not care for your lineage or your gods. They care for iron, tea, and the weight of a sworn oath. Aeler and Dhaharan have bled into the same stone here. I wear a dwarf’s breath-counter and a Dhaharan fire-token. The mountain accepts both. The lowland kings may dream of unity, but the iron does not dream. It only waits.”

Elephant Mahout (Commoner): “My grandfather drove elephants for the Sun Kings. My father drove them for the Aeler. I drive them for the Viceroy. The elephants do not care who holds the howdah. They care that the pass is clear and the fodder is fresh. They also remember the old songs — the ones about the ninth kingdom that never was.”

Genre / Mood: Elephant warfare, monsoon ritual, honour as ancestral dharma, high-altitude survival horror, industrial colonialism.

Starting Location: The Peacock Throne Hall in Ahimsa, where a golden peacock with ruby eyes watches the court. The Maharaja’s chamberlain approaches: “The Maharaja wishes to renew the Nine-Kingdom Pact. But the King of Vajrapur has sent a forged genealogy. The Queen of Mahishmati has refused to attend. And the ninth kingdom — the one that is always missing — has sent a messenger. The messenger is a ghost. Meanwhile, Viceroy Thrain has sent a breath-counter and a demand: the iron tithe is due. Speak carefully. The peacock is watching.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between the high passes of the Aeler viceroyalty and the Brass Coast lies a fertile, contested lowland: the land of the Nine Kingdoms, the heart of Dhahara. Here, ancient dynasties still claim descent from the sun, and the Peacock Throne of Ahimsa casts its shadow over half a dozen rival courts. Rivers are borders; elephants are war machines; every harvest is a negotiation between kings who have never met but whose grandfathers swore blood oaths. The Covenant has a strong presence in the sacred cities; the Aeler have counting houses in the iron towns; the Sidhi sail up the rivers to trade. But Dhahara belongs to the Dhaharan — to their poets, their temple dancers, their bandit kings, and their queens who rule from behind silk screens.

North, in the high passes, the Aeler viceroys rule on behalf of the distant High King. Here, the air is thin and cold, the rivers run white with snowmelt, and the passes are measured in breath-counts rather than miles. Iron mines scar the hillsides, worked by Dhaharan labourers and overseen by Aeler engineers. Elephant caravans haul ore down to the Brass Coast; mule trains carry silver and tea up to the mountain holds. The Aeler have established a viceroyalty here — not conquest, but a long lease, renewed every nine years. The local rajas pay tribute in iron and receive protection from lowland enemies. It is an uneasy peace, written in bell-codes and toll-stones. The architecture blends Aeler stonework with Dhaharan domes; the cuisine mixes dwarf-bread with spiced tea; the law is a creole of Covenant statutes and Aeler breath-bonds.

But both north and south share a common truth: the number “nine” is a wound — and a promise. There have never been nine kingdoms. The number is a ritual, a prayer that the Hollow will not notice that one of the nine is always missing. That missing kingdom changes. Sometimes it is a real kingdom that fell to plague or war; sometimes it is a kingdom that never was, a placeholder kept empty to balance the cosmic scales. The Peacock Throne weeps because the missing kingdom is always the one that mattered — and because the Hollow collects the weight of its absence. In the high passes, the ninth breath is the one the mountain takes. In the lowlands, the ninth throne is the one the Hollow watches. North and south, the obligation is the same.

What you notice first: The smell of jasmine and dust, and the ringing of iron hammers. The way every crossroads has a painted stone — a boundary marker, a warning, a prayer. The constant murmur of bazaars where haggling is a form of theatre. The way every noble touches their left wrist when speaking of ancestors — a gesture of honour. The silence after a bell rings in the mountains — the silence is for the mountain to answer.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one — a breath, a memory, a shadow. In the lowlands, never praise a king’s elephant. The elephant is sacred; your praise will be taken as an insult to the king’s own mount. Compliment the mahout instead. The mahout will tell the elephant.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Elephant and the Gaze of the Hollow

Power here is measured in river rights, elephant herds, the thickness of a dynasty’s archive, and the number of breaths a miner can hold. In the lowlands, a king’s authority rests on how many generations back to the sun — but also on how many of those generations kept their promises. The Peacock Throne of Ahimsa is the nominal centre, but the other eight kings vie for influence, and the balance shifts with every monsoon. The Covenant judges provide legal arbitration; the temple dancers control the ritual calendar; the bandit kings of Kalinga pay no tribute to anyone. In the high passes, the Viceroy answers to the Aeler High King, but also to the local rajas, the Covenant judges, and the elephant clans. Every decision is a negotiation between mountain custom and lowland law. The Aeler engineers speak a creole of their own tongue; the Dhaharan nobles wear Aeler breath-counters as jewellery; and the elephants — the elephants remember who fed them during the famine of the ninth lease.

And somewhere, in the gap between the eighth and the ninth — between the eighth breath and the ninth breath, between the eighth throne and the ninth throne — the Hollow waits to collect what the missing kingdom owes.

Prominent NPCs of Dhahara

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15 Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Maharaja Suryavarman	King of Ahimsa (Peacock Throne)	Unite the nine under his dynasty	His pet peacock follows him; its cry is a warning of assassination attempts.
Viceroy Thrain	Aeler governor of the Iron Passes	Maximise ore output for the High King	He wears a bell around his neck; it rings when he lies.
Rani Chandravati	Queen of Vajrapur (Iron Kingdom)	Protect the iron mines from Aeler encroachment	She wears a bracelet of dwarf teeth — each tooth is from an engineer she outwitted.
King Bhim	Buffalo King of Mahishmati	Expand his pastoral kingdom into Anga	He has never lost a buffalo race; his buffalo is named “Conqueror.”
Covenant High Judge Vasu	Head of the Kosala sacred circuit	Enforce contract law across the nine kingdoms	He carries a scale that never balances; he says justice is never equal, only weighed.
Temple Dancer Mira	Devadasi of the Peacock Throne	Keep the peace through ritual	Her dance is said to bring rain; she has stopped three droughts. She dreams of the missing ninth.
Mine-Captain Korr	Aeler engineer in the high passes	Keep the tunnels safe and the quotas met	He counts his breaths in eights; he has never reached nine.

Rani Jaya Local raja of the eastern hills (high passes) Balance tribute to Aeler with loyalty to her clan She lost an arm to a mine collapse; the prosthetic is a pickaxe.

Prince Karna of Anga Heir to the eastern fortress Recover the lost tunnels of Anga He walks with a limp from a childhood tiger attack; the tiger was his mother's pet.

Bandit Queen Jaya Ruler of the Kalinga hills Carve a tenth kingdom from the margins Her parrot is a transformed spy; it still works for three masters.

Scribe Govinda Master of the Silent Court Keep the Covenant's secrets from leaking He writes with a quill made from a dead man's finger — the finger of a forger.

Tarkan Elephant caravan master (high passes) Move iron to the coast before the snows close the passes He speaks to his elephants in Dhaharan; they answer in Aeler.

The Ninth King's Herald (Ghost) A translucent messenger who appears at every succession crisis Remind the living that the missing kingdom still has a vote It speaks in the voice of the last king of the lost ninth. That voice changes each time.

Names of Dhahara

Sanskrit and Prakrit roots, with honourifics (Rao, Singh, Deva, Bai). In the high passes, Aeler clan names and Dhaharan hill titles mix. Surnames often denote clan, profession, or a specific mine. A character's full name includes an honour-syllable (*-rinn*, *-datt*, *-hrin*), spoken only when swearing oaths.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/Surname	Epithets
Surya	Chandravati	Somavamsi	<i>the Peacock</i>
Bhim	Mira	Kalachuri	<i>Iron-Fisted</i>
Vasu	Ganga	Yadava	<i>Buffalo-Loyal</i>
Rajendra	Lakshmi	Gupta	<i>the Coin-Eater</i>
Krishna	Durga	Pala	<i>the Learned</i>
Karna	Jaya	Malla	<i>the Unseen</i>
Govinda	Tara	Shailendra	<i>the Silent</i>
Thrain	Jaya	Ironfoot	<i>the Bell-Breaker</i>
Korr	Gaura	Stonehand	<i>Breath-Counter</i>
Borin	Meera	Vikram	<i>the Elephant's Friend</i>

(**Lowland**) Hall of the Peacock Throne, Iron Gate Market, Buffalo Race Track, Sacred City of Sravasti, Anga Fort, Western Port of Surashtra, Rajagriha Ruins, Elephant Stables

of Ahimsa, Well of the Nine Kings, Forgotten Throne of Kalinga, Silent Court of Kosala, Peacock Gardens, Whispering Pass, Nine Kings' Tomb.

(Highland) Iron Mine of the Crying Face, Aeler Toll Bridge, Viceroy's Hall, Elephant Corral (Mountain), Silent Pass, Mine of the Ninth Seal, Tea Terraces (Aeler-Dhaharan), Dwarf Counting-House, Raja's Fort (Hill), Bridge of Nine Echoes, Abandoned Smelter, Viceroy's Archive, First Lease Stone.

Spades — Lowland Places (Nine Kingdoms)

2. **Peacock Throne Hall** — A vast chamber with pillars of carved marble; the throne is a peacock of gold and lapis lazuli. '[AUTHORITY]' *The peacock's eyes are rubies. They follow anyone who approaches the throne. The throne has never been sat upon by a usurper. The ninth eye is missing — it fell out during the last succession war and was never replaced.*
3. **Iron Gate Market (Vajrapur)** — A bazaar outside the fortress; the smell of iron dust and spices. '[TRADE]' *The market has a section where slaves are sold. The slaves wear iron collars stamped with the king's mark. One collar is always empty — reserved for the ghost of the missing ninth kingdom.*
4. **Buffalo Race Track (Mahishmati)** — A dusty oval; the betting is fierce. '[SPORT]' *The track has a shrine at the centre — a buffalo that never lost. Its skeleton is on display. The skeleton sometimes snorts. When it does, a promise is about to come due.*
5. **Sacred City of Sravasti (Kosala)** — A walled city with a thousand temples; the Covenant courthouse is here. '[JUSTICE]' *The city has no bells. The Covenant forbids them. The silence is enforced by armed judges. The silence is loudest at noon. The ninth temple has no door.*
6. **Anga Fort** — A hilltop fortress with a dry moat; the walls are painted with tiger stripes. '[DEFENSE]' *The fortress has never been taken. The king's secret is a network of hidden tunnels. The tunnels have not been mapped in a century. One tunnel leads to the missing ninth kingdom — or so the ghosts say.*
7. **Western Port of Surashtra** — A Sidhi trading post; the harbour is full of dhows. '[TRADE]' *The port has a lighthouse shaped like a woman. The woman is a Sidhi saint. Her lamp is lit with green flame. The flame flickers when a ninth kingdom obligation is recalled.*
8. **Rajagriha Ruins** — The former imperial capital, now a graveyard of broken pillars. '[RUINS]' '[DEATH]' *The ruins are haunted by the ghosts of Gupta emperors. They ask for news of their empire. They do not accept bad news. They also ask who sits on the ninth throne.*

9. **Elephant Stables of Ahimsa** — A complex of stone stalls; each elephant has its own name carved above the door. '[COMMUNITY]' *The names are not the elephants' birth names. They are the names of enemies they trampled. The elephants remember. One stall is always empty — for the elephant that carried the ninth king.*
10. **Well of the Nine Kings** — A deep stepwell with nine landings; each landing has a statue of a different king. '[MYSTERY]' *The water is black. It shows the face of the next king to die. The face changes when you blink. The ninth landing shows only a reflection of the viewer — the missing king is always you.*
11. **Forgotten Throne of Kalinga** — A stone chair sunk in a marsh; the Bandit Queen holds court there. '[SECRET]' *The throne was once a king's. He lost a bet. The bet was his kingdom. The marsh still smells of that laughter. The throne has a ninth armrest, worn smooth by no hand.*
- J **Silent Court of Kosala** — A Covenant courthouse with no speaking allowed; all arguments are written. '[JUSTICE]' *The judges write their verdicts in disappearing ink. Only they know the secret reagent. The reagent is tears. The ninth judge has no face — only a veil of grey silk.*
- Q **Peacock Gardens** — A walled garden behind the throne hall; only the king may enter. '[LEGEND]' *The garden contains a single peacock that is immortal. It was the first king's familiar. It has not eaten in three hundred years. It has nine feathers in its tail. One falls each time a kingdom dies.*
- K **Whispering Pass (Anga-Mahishmati)** — A narrow defile where the wind carries conversations. '[SPY]' *Spies use it to listen to enemy camps. The pass is named for the dead — they whisper too. Their whispers are always true. The ninth whisper is always a name you have never heard.*
- A **Nine Kings' Tomb** — A subterranean complex where the founders of each dynasty are buried. '[DEATH]' '[LEGEND]' *The tomb is sealed. The key is a single word that changes each year — the name of the current weakest king. The word is never spoken aloud. The ninth sarcophagus is empty. It waits.*

Spades — Highland Places (Mountain Satrapies)

2. **Iron Mine of the Crying Face** — A deep shaft with a carved face above the entrance. *The face weeps rust. The tears are iron oxide. The mountain is mourning its dead.* '[BREATH]'
3. **Aeler Toll Bridge** — A stone arch over a gorge; a dwarf with a scale sits at the far end. *The toll is not in coin — it is in weight. Your truth is weighed against a bar of iron.* '[TOLL]'
4. **Viceroy's Hall** — A longhouse of timber and stone; a throne of iron ore. *The throne is cold. The viceroy never sits on it — only stands behind it.* '[LEASE]'

5. **Elephant Corral (Mountain)** — A fenced area with heavy chains; elephants are chained by one leg. *The chains have names — each is the elephant's first kill.* '[COMMUNITY]'
6. **Silent Pass** — A high mountain pass where no bird flies. *The air is too thin for sound. Arguments must be written in the snow.* '[BREATH]'
7. **Mine of the Ninth Seal** — A sealed tunnel with a Covenant seal on the timbers. *Inside is a demon that the miners woke. The seal is cracking.* '[MAGIC]' '[LEASE]'
8. **Tea Terraces (Aeler-Dhaharan)** — Stone-step fields where tea shrubs grow. *Each terrace is a different clan's share of the harvest. The tea tastes of slate.* '[TRADE]'
9. **Dwarf Counting-House** — A low building with brass scales and an iron record. *The record tracks breath-bonds. It weighs the air.* '[TOLL]'
10. **Raja's Fort (Hill)** — A stone fortress with painted gates and a single tower. *The tower is also a fire shrine. The flame is lit with dwarf-coal.* '[COMMUNITY]'
- J **Bridge of Nine Echoes** — A rope bridge over a chasm; each step echoes nine times. *The ninth echo is always a whisper. It is the name of the next person to fall.* '[OMEN]'
- Q **Abandoned Smelter** — A ruined furnace where iron was once refined. *The slag heaps are still warm. Something lives in the warmth.* '[MAGIC]'
- K **Viceroy's Archive** — A subterranean vault of treaties and toll receipts. *The archive is sealed with Aeler keystone wax and Dhaharan clay.* '[LEASE]'
- A **The First Lease Stone** — A monolith carved with the original treaty between Aeler and Dhahara. *The stone is warm. It glows when the lease is renewed. It cracks when the lease is broken.* '[LEASE]' '[OMEN]'

(Lowland NPCs) Peacock Throne chamberlain, iron mines overseer (dwarf), buffalo herder, Covenant judge (High Judge Vasu), temple dancer (Mira), bandit of Kalinga, spice merchant (Sidhi), poet of the Peacock Throne, well keeper of the Nine Kings, war elephant mahout, ghost of Rajagriha, silent judge's clerk, peacock keeper, ninth king's ghost.

(Highland NPCs) Mine-captain (Aeler), Rani Jaya, Covenant judge (Sister Gaura), elephant caravan master (Tarkan), Aeler toll-keeper, smelter worker, treasure hunter, raja's spymaster, tea trader (Fhara), blind pilgrim, ghost of the landslide, viceroy's cipher clerk, demon's whisper (from the Ninth Seal).

Hearts — Lowland People & Factions

2. **Peacock Throne Chamberlain** — A eunuch in silk; he controls access to the king. '[AUTHORITY]' *He has a mirror on a stick; he uses it to see around corners. He has seen nine assassins before they struck. He has not warned the king about the tenth. The tenth works for the missing kingdom.*

3. **Iron Mines Overseer (Dwarf)** — Wears an Aeler breath-counter. He is loyal to the queen, but his cousin is a viceroy's clerk. '[POLITICS]' *He keeps two records. One is for the queen. One is for the Aeler. Both are forgeries. The truth is in his head. He is losing his memory. The ninth entry in every record is always wrong.*
4. **Buffalo Herder** — A young man with a staff and a red turban. '[COMMUNITY]' *He can find water in a drought by listening to the ground. His buffalo have never gone thirsty. He shares his wells with travellers. The ninth well he dug produced blood instead of water. He does not speak of it.*
5. **Covenant Judge (High Judge Vasu)** — A grey-haired man with a brass scale. He has never smiled. '[JUSTICE]' *His clerks have never seen him eat. He drinks only rainwater. He says food clouds the mind. His judgments are always delivered at noon. The ninth judgment he ever made was never recorded. It was for the missing kingdom.*
6. **Temple Dancer (Mira)** — A woman with anklets of silver and eyes lined with kohl. '[RITUAL]' *Her dance is a prayer. The prayer is for peace. She has never failed — but the peace never lasts. She dances anyway. In the ninth step of her dance, she always stumbles slightly. No one knows why.*
7. **Bandit of Kalinga** — A man with a parrot on his shoulder, a scar across his face. '[STEALTH]' *The parrot is his conscience. It screams when he lies. He lies often. The parrot has lost its voice. It regained it once, to name the ninth king's murderer. The name was never spoken aloud.*
8. **Spice Merchant (Sidhi)** — A Sidhi trader with a leather bag full of cinnamon. He speaks seven languages. '[TRADE]' *He lies in all of them. His weights are true, though. He says the weights are the only honest thing about him. The ninth weight in his set is a forgery — it is exactly one grain lighter. He uses it to pay obligations to the Hollow.*
9. **Poet of the Peacock Throne** — A woman with a stringed instrument, her voice cracked from singing. '[SOCIAL]' *She writes verses for the king. The verses are encoded warnings. The king cannot read. He has her sing them instead. Her ninth verse is a curse that activates when the missing kingdom returns. She prays it never does.*
10. **Well Keeper of the Nine Kings** — A blind woman who sits by the stepwell. '[MYSTERY]' *She knows the depth of the water by the echo of a dropped stone. She knows the future by the same echo. She does not charge for her visions. She charges for the silence afterwards. The ninth echo always says the same word: "Wait."*
11. **War Elephant Mahout** — An old man who has never lost a battle. He whispers to his elephant in a language of clicks. '[COMBAT]' *The elephant's name is "Sorry." It has trampled nine enemies. It always apologises. The ninth apology was accepted by a ghost. The ghost now rides beside it.*

- J **Ghost of Rajagriha** — A translucent figure in a crown. He asks one question: “Does my empire still stand?” ‘[DEATH]’ *The answer must be a lie, or he will weep and flood the ruins. The lie must be kind. He can tell the difference. He has asked the question nine times. The ninth answer was silence. He is still waiting.*
- Q **Silent Judge’s Clerk** — A young woman who writes in disappearing ink. She is the only one who knows the reagent. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *She has been attacked twice. She carries a dagger made of frozen ink. The ink melts after one use. The ninth time she uses it, the dagger will not melt. She does not know what that means.*
- K **Peacock Keeper** — A boy who tends the immortal peacock. The peacock speaks to him. ‘[LEGEND]’ *It tells him which courtiers are plotting. The boy has never been wrong. He does not tell the king. He tells the peacock. The peacock has nine warnings stored. It will speak the ninth when the missing kingdom returns.*
- A **Ninth King’s Ghost** — A shade that walks the tomb. It points at the killer — but the killer is always a living king. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *It points at whoever is closest. That person is accused. The accusation is always false. The crowd does not care. The ninth time it points, it will point at the true killer. No one will believe it.*

Hearts — Highland People & Factions

2. **Mine-Captain (Aeler)** — A dwarf with a tuning fork and a level. He can hear a crack in a beam from a hundred paces. *He never walks under a keystone. The mountain has ears.* ‘[BREATH]’
3. **Rani Jaya** — A young woman in armour, riding a caparisoned elephant. She lost an arm to a mine collapse. *The prosthetic is a pickaxe. She can write with it. The letters are iron filings.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
4. **Covenant Judge (Sister Gaura)** — Robed in grey, a water-clock on her belt. The clock runs on tears. *She refills it from her own eyes when she hands down a death sentence.* ‘[LEASE]’
5. **Elephant Caravan Master (Tarkan)** — Old, missing two fingers, tattooed with elephant footprints. *He knows the name of every elephant that has crossed the pass in fifty years.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
6. **Aeler Toll-Keeper** — A dwarf with a brass scale and a record. He weighs your goods and your lies. *The scale tips for both. A lie makes the pan dip lower.* ‘[TOLL]’
7. **Smelter Worker** — A young man with red-rimmed eyes. He coughs iron dust. *His spittle stains the ground. He will not live past thirty. He knows.* ‘[LABOR]’
8. **Treasure Hunter** — A foreigner digging in an old landslide. He is looking for the tomb of a prince. *The prince is the one who stole the Kalrantha amulet. The treasure hunter is a fool.* ‘[MAGIC]’

9. **Raja's Spymaster** — A woman with a limp; she uses a walking stick that is also a blowpipe. *The darts are tipped with tea — caffeine that stops hearts.* '[POLITICS]'
10. **Tea Trader (Fhara)** — A merchant with a caravan of mules. He sells tea to the Aeler; they pay in iron. *He sells iron to the coast; they pay in silver. He is the richest man in the passes.* '[TRADE]'
- J **Blind Pilgrim** — A woman in white, walking the passes alone. She is searching for a shrine where a bell rang without a clapper. *The shrine is a cave. The cave is the mine of the ninth seal.* '[FAITH]'
- Q **Ghost of the Landslide** — A figure in grey, seen only at dusk. It points at the pass. *It is pointing at a safe route — or a trap. No one has survived to find out.* '[OMEN]'
- K **Viceroy's Cipher Clerk** — A dwarf who writes diplomatic letters in code. *The code is a poem. The poem is about a lost mine. The mine is real.* '[LEASE]'
- A **Demon's Whisper (from the Ninth Seal)** — A voice heard in the sealed mine. *It offers a deal: a year of good fortune for a single memory. The memory is the last breath of a dying friend.* '[MAGIC]' '[LEASE]'

(Lowland Complications) Elephant stampede — trained to kill; buffalo race riot — crowd turns violent; Covenant excommunication — contract voided, goods seized; temple dance cursed — the rain does not come; spy in the Peacock Gardens; Nine Kings' Tomb robbers; Well of Nine Kings poisoned; Peacock Throne assassination attempt; Silent Court leak; royal genealogy forged; Whispering Pass ambush; immortal peacock's cry; ghost's demand; well's vision.

(Highland Complications) Cave-In (sabotage); toll dispute; ninth echo on the Bridge of Nine Echoes; landslide; breath shortage; spy in camp; Covenant audit; Aeler bell code change; elephant sickness (curse); Viceroy's summons; Silent Pass's cold; demon wakes (Ninth Seal); lease stone cracks.

Clubs — Lowland Complications/Threats

2. **Elephant Stampede (Royal)** — The king's elephants break loose; they are trained to kill. '[DISASTER]' '[COMBAT]'. *The stampede was ordered by a rival queen. The target is a visiting diplomat. The diplomat is you. The elephants are not confused. One elephant wears a saddle from the missing ninth kingdom.*
3. **Buffalo Race Riot** — A disputed finish; the crowd turns violent. '[SOCIAL]' '[COMBAT]'. *The dispute is a trap. The losing king wants an excuse to invade. You are the excuse. The buffalo are innocent. The ninth buffalo in the race has no shadow.*
4. **Covenant Excommunication** — High Judge Vasu declares your contract void; your goods are seized. '[JUSTICE]' '[WEIGHT]'. *The excommunication is a*

bribe. The bribe was paid by a merchant you undercut. The merchant is in the crowd, smiling. He wears a ninth ring on a hand that has only eight fingers.

5. **Temple Dance Cursed** — Mira stumbles; the rain does not come. The priest blames the party. '[RITUAL]' '[SOCIAL]' *The sacrifice is a goat. The goat is a spy. The spy is working for Vajrapur. The goat will not stop talking. It speaks of the ninth kingdom in a language that sounds like bells.*
6. **Spy in the Peacock Gardens** — Someone overheard the king's war plans. '[POLITICS]' '[STEALTH]' *The spy is a poet. The poet is you — you were hired to write verses, not to eavesdrop. The king has a long memory for verse. The verse you overheard was the ninth stanza of a forbidden epic.*
7. **Nine Kings' Tomb Robbers** — Grave robbers break into the tomb. They seek the key word. '[DEATH]' '[THEFT]' *The word is "forgiveness." The robbers are agents of a rival kingdom. They do not know the word. They are digging anyway. The ninth sarcophagus is open. It is empty. The robbers did not open it.*
8. **Well of Nine Kings Poisoned** — The black water turns red; people sicken. '[DEATH]' '[WEATHER]' *The poison was placed by an Ashaani agent. The agent wants to destabilise the kingdoms. The water tastes of iron and old regrets. The ninth victim sees the face of the missing king before they die.*
9. **Peacock Throne Assassination Attempt** — A courtier tries to kill the king. '[POLITICS]' '[COMBAT]' *The assassin is the chamberlain. The chamberlain is a spy for Vajrapur. He has been waiting nine years. His hands do not shake. He has a ninth dagger hidden in his mirror-stick.*
10. **Silent Court Leak** — A judge's verdict is revealed before it is read. '[JUSTICE]' '[SOCIAL]' *The leak is a clerk. The clerk is selling secrets to the Bandit King. The verdict is your death. The clerk is sorry. He is not sorry enough. The ninth page of the verdict is blank — reserved for an appeal from the missing kingdom.*
11. **Royal Genealogy Forged** — Someone has altered the king's family tree. The claimant is an impostor — or maybe not. '[POLITICS]' *The forger is a Lethai-thora archivist who lost a bet. The bet was with the Hollow. The Hollow always wins. The ninth generation on the tree is written in disappearing ink. It shows a name that cannot be read.*
- J **Whispering Pass Ambush** — The party is caught in a crossfire between two kingdoms. '[COMBAT]' '[STEALTH]' *The pass is neutral ground. Both sides will claim you are a spy. Choose a side — or escape. The wind will carry your choice to both. The ninth whisper in the pass says, "You should have run."*
- Q **Immortal Peacock's Cry** — The peacock screams; the court panics. '[OMEN]' '[FEAR]' *The cry is a warning. An assassin is in the hall. The assassin is a guest. The peacock will not say which one. It wants to watch. The peacock has not screamed in nine years. The last time it screamed, the ninth kingdom fell.*

- K Ghost's Demand (Ninth King)** — The ghost points at you. It accuses you of murdering the king's descendant. '[DEATH]' '[SOCIAL]' *The descendant is an infant. You must prove your innocence. The ghost will not be reasoned with. It will accept a trade: one secret for one life. The ninth secret you offer will be taken by the Hollow.*
- A Well's Vision** — One PC sees their own face in the black water. The face is old, scarred, and weeping. '[MYSTERY]' '[FEAR]' *The well says: "This is your future if you stay." The vision is true — but only for this moment. The moment is passing. The ninth reflection shows a face that is not yours — it is the missing king's. You feel an obligation you cannot name.*

Clubs — Highland Complications/Threats

2. **Cave-In (Sabotage)** — A tunnel collapses. The collapse was not an accident — a saboteur loosened the timbers. '[DISASTER]' *The saboteur is in the party. Or the party is accused.*
3. **Toll Dispute** — The Aeler keeper demands double; the raja's men refuse. The dispute is a trap. '[TOLL]' '[POLITICS]' *Both sides want the party to choose a side. Neither is honest.*
4. **Ninth Echo** — On the Bridge of Nine Echoes, someone counts the echoes. The ninth echo says a name. '[OMEN]' '[FEAR]' *The name is the speaker's. They faint. The bridge remembers.*
5. **Landslide** — The pass is blocked. The alternative route is three days longer. '[WEATHER]' '[TRAVEL]' *The landslide was deliberate — a rival caravan master wants to delay you.*
6. **Breath Shortage** — At high altitude, the party struggles. Mark Fatigue 1 per scene. '[BREATH]' '[ENDURANCE]' *Acclimatisation requires a rest day. The rest day will cost a toll.*
7. **Spy in Camp** — A worker is stealing iron samples. The spy is working for an Ashaani agent. '[POLITICS]' '[STEALTH]' *The samples are for a new alloy. The alloy is a weapon.*
8. **Covenant Audit** — Sister Gaura demands to inspect the party's cargo. '[LEASE]' '[JUSTICE]' *The cargo includes a relic from the Red Desert — a stolen Covenant seal.*
9. **Aeler Bell Code Change** — The toll-keeper rings a different sequence; the party is now "unregistered." '[TOLL]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The change was ordered by the viceroy. The viceroy is testing your loyalty.*
10. **Elephant Sickness (Curse)** — A disease spreads through the caravan. The disease is a curse from a local spirit. '[COMMUNITY]' '[MAGIC]' *The spirit was disturbed by the mine's expansion. It wants a sacrifice — a memory, not blood.*

J Viceroy's Summons — Thrain demands the party attend him. He offers a deal: find the saboteur in exchange for a toll waiver. '[LEASE]' '[POLITICS]' *The saboteur is his own clerk. The clerk is his daughter.*

Q Silent Pass's Cold — The temperature drops; the party loses 1 Supply per hour. '[WEATHER]' '[BREATH]' *The cold is supernatural — a frost spirit has taken residence. It wants a memory.*

K Demon Wakes (Ninth Seal) — The sealed mine cracks open. A shadow escapes; it possesses the nearest Aeler engineer. '[MAGIC]' '[LEASE]' *The engineer begins to sabotage the pass. The demon wants the lease broken.*

A Lease Stone Cracks — The First Lease Stone glows red and splits. The treaty is void. War is coming. '[LEASE]' '[APOCALYPSE]' *The party has one day to flee the passes before the Aeler and Dhaharan armies clash.*

(Lowland Rewards) Peacock feather (enter any court); iron gate pass (brass key); buffalo horn trumpet; Covenant seal (Kosala); temple dancer's anklet (silver); Rajagriha coin; well water (vial); Silent Court disappearing ink (bottle); Nine Kings' key word ("forgiveness"); elephant whistle (bone); immortal peacock's second feather; Whispering Pass's map (ear); Peacock Throne's blessing (decree); ninth king's crown (gold circlet).

(Highland Rewards) Aeler breath-counter (silver bell); iron ingot (viceroy's mark); Covenant seal (clay, Himadri); toll waiver (brass nail); elephant whistle (bone); raja's signet ring (silver); smelter's gloves (asbestos); map of the Silent Pass (leather); viceroy's letter of introduction; blind pilgrim's staff; demon's nail (sealed mine timber); ninth echo's whisper (recording); viceroy's forgiveness (pardon).

Diamonds — Lowland Rewards/Leverage

2. **Peacock Feather** — A single iridescent feather from the immortal peacock. Present it to enter any court in the nine kingdoms. '[SOCIAL]' *The feather never fades. It glows when the king is lying. It glows brighter when you are lying. The king will notice. The ninth feather in the peacock's tail is invisible. If you find it, you can command the peacock to speak.*
3. **Iron Gate Pass (Brass Key)** — A brass key. Bypass customs at Vajrapur's market. '[TRAVEL]' *The key is also a weapon. It can break chains. It was forged from a slave collar. The slave's ghost thanks you every time you use it. The ghost was a king of the missing ninth. He does not remember his name.*
4. **Buffalo Horn Trumpet** — A carved horn. Blow it to summon a buffalo cavalry. '[COMBAT]' *The cavalry are mercenaries. They demand payment in land. One acre per horn blast. They will accept a story instead — if the story is about a lost battlefield. The ninth cavalryman is a ghost. He fights for free, but he will ask you a question after the battle. Answer poorly, and he takes a memory.*

5. **Covenant Seal (Kosala)** — A clay seal. Witness any contract in the sacred city. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The seal is fragile. It breaks if the contract is false. The breaking is loud. The sound carries for a mile. Everyone will know. The ninth seal ever made is still intact. It seals a contract with the missing kingdom. No one has dared to break it.*
 6. **Temple Dancer’s Anklet (Silver)** — A silver anklet with bells. Wear it to gain +1 die to any persuasion roll. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The bells are silent unless you are honest. Dishonest words make no sound. The silence is more damning than a lie. The ninth bell on the anklet rings only when the monsoon is about to fail. It has rung twice in living memory.*
 7. **Rajagriha Coin** — A Gupta-era gold coin. Trade it for a favour from the ghosts. ‘[DEATH]’ *The ghosts will answer one question about the empire’s fall. The answer is always a warning. The warning is always about you. The ninth coin in the hoard is cursed. Spend it, and a ghost of the missing kingdom will follow you until you return it.*
 8. **Well Water (Vial)** — A vial of black water from the Nine Kings’ Well. Drink it to see the future. ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The future is always a death — yours or someone else’s. The vision lasts one minute. You will not forget it. The ninth vial was never drawn. It is reserved for the king who will unite the nine. The well knows your name. It is waiting.*
 9. **Silent Court Disappearing Ink (Bottle)** — A small bottle. Write a message that vanishes. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The reagent is your own tears. The message reappears when you weep. The reappearance is permanent. Choose your tears carefully. The ninth bottle contains ink that never disappears. It is used to write the names of those who owe the Hollow.*
 10. **Nine Kings’ Key Word** — A single word: “forgiveness.” Speak it to open the tomb. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The word also opens a lock in the Peacock Throne Hall. The lock is a secret door. The door leads to a room that contains the king’s true genealogy. The genealogy shows that every king of Ahimsa is a descendant of the missing ninth kingdom. The weight is never lifted.*
 11. **Elephant Whistle (Bone)** — Carved from a tusk of a battle elephant. Blow it to calm any elephant within earshot — once. ‘[BEAST]’ *The whistle was owned by a mahout who never lost. He is still alive. He wants it back. The elephant that carried the ninth king used a whistle like this. Its ghost can be summoned by blowing it three times at midnight.*
- J Immortal Peacock’s Second Feather** — A tail feather from the immortal peacock. It is said to grant a wish. ‘[LEGEND]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The wish is that the king will die. Use it wisely. The feather burns after use. The peacock will know. It will not forgive. The ninth wish ever made with a peacock feather was: “Let the missing kingdom return.” The peacock is still deciding.*

- Q Whispering Pass's Map (Ear)** — A chart of the defile and its listening posts. Written on a human ear. '[SPY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The ear was from a spy. It still hears whispers. Hold it to your own ear to listen to distant conversations. The ear will whisper back. Do not answer. The ninth whisper you hear will be your own voice, asking a question you have never asked.*
- K Peacock Throne's Blessing (Decree)** — A royal decree. Demand a favour from any king of the nine. '[AUTHORITY]' *The favour is limited: they will not start a war for you, but they will end one. They will also end a blood feud, a trade embargo, or a marriage alliance. The ninth favour was claimed by the missing kingdom. The king who granted it is still trying to fulfil it.*
- A Ninth King's Crown (Gold Circlet)** — Found in the tomb. Wear it to command the ghosts of Rajagriha. '[DEATH]' '[LEGEND]' *They will fight for you once. Then they will claim you as their king. You cannot leave the ruins. The ruins will grow around you. The ghosts will keep you company. The ninth ghost is the missing king himself. He will ask you one question: "Why did you let me fall?" You have one sentence to answer.*

Diamonds — Highland Rewards/Leverage

2. **Aeler Breath-Counter (Silver Bell)** — Wear it to count your breaths in high altitude. The bell rings when you reach eight. '[BREATH]' '[TRAVEL]' *Stop at eight. The ninth breath is the mountain's.*
3. **Iron Ingot (Viceroy's Mark)** — A single bar of high-grade iron, stamped with a dragon. Worth 1 Measure. '[TRADE]' '[LEVERAGE]' *The dragon is the viceroy's mark. Present it to any Aeler forge for a favour.*
4. **Covenant Seal (Clay, Himadri)** — A lump of clay. Heat it to witness any oath in the foothills. '[LEASE]' '[JUSTICE]' *The heat comes from a coal taken from the sealed mine. The coal whispers.*
5. **Toll Waiver (Brass Nail)** — A brass nail. Present it to pass any Aeler bridge for free. '[TOLL]' '[TRAVEL]' *The nail fits into a hole in the toll-keeper's scale. The hole is for bribes.*
6. **Elephant Whistle (Bone)** — A bone whistle. Blow it to call an elephant from the caravan. '[COMMUNITY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The whistle is made from the tusk of a bull that died in a rockslide. Its ghost runs with the elephant.*
7. **Raja's Signet Ring (Silver)** — A silver ring with a tiger. Commands loyalty from the raja's clan. '[COMMUNITY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The ring is a copy. The real one was lost in a landslide. The ghost of the original owner wears it.*

8. **Smelter's Gloves (Asbestos)** — Handle hot metal safely. The gloves are cursed: they itch when you lie. '[CRAFT]' '[TRUTH]' *The itch is mild at first. It becomes unbearable with repeated lies.*
9. **Map of the Silent Pass (Leather)** — A chart drawn on leather. Shows a safe route through the high pass. '[TRAVEL]' '[SECRET]' *The map is incomplete. The missing section is a fold. The fold is a secret — a cave with a spring.*
10. **Viceroy's Letter of Introduction** — A sealed scroll. Grants access to any Aeler hold in the mountains. '[LEASE]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The letter is written in blood. The blood is the viceroy's. He changes his blood type each season.*
- J **Blind Pilgrim's Staff** — A wooden staff with a bell on top. Ring it to summon a guide. '[FAITH]' '[TRAVEL]' *The guide is a ghost — the pilgrim's predecessor. She will lead you safely, but she will ask for a story.*
- Q **Demon's Nail (Sealed Mine Timber)** — A piece of the sealed mine's timber. Touch it to a lock; the lock opens. '[MAGIC]' '[STEALTH]' *The lock also screams. The scream alerts the demon.*
- K **Ninth Echo's Whisper (Recording)** — A piece of slate carved with the ninth echo's words. Play it to silence a foe. '[COMBAT]' '[FEAR]' *The foe hears their own name and freezes for one exchange. The slate then crumbles.*
- A **Viceroy's Forgiveness (Pardon)** — A written pardon for any crime in the Satrapies. '[LEASE]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The pardon is conditional. The condition is a secret mission. The mission is to assassinate a rival viceroy.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (feathers, keys, seals, bells, ingots) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **Dhaharan omens**—peacock feathers shed without reason, a well that reflects a face not yours, a throne that creaks when empty, a whisper that counts to nine, iron that weeps rust, a pass that closes behind you, a bell that rings without a clapper.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Nine Kingdoms Pact Clock [8]:** Tracks the cohesion of the lowland alliance. Advances when a kingdom sends a false genealogy, when a king refuses to attend the renewal, or when a border raid occurs. At 4 segments: tariffs increase between

kingdoms. At 8: the pact collapses — war is declared, and the Peacock Throne becomes a target. If the Pact Clock ever fills completely, the missing kingdom’s ghost appears at the next renewal to cast a vote. No one knows which way it will vote.

- **The Ninth Kingdom Clock [8]:** Tracks the return of the missing kingdom. This clock is hidden from players at first, but they may learn of it through research or the Well of Nine Kings. The clock ticks when:
 - A king dies without a clear heir (+1)
 - A genealogy is proven false (+1)
 - A temple dancer stumbles during the monsoon ritual (+2)
 - The immortal peacock screams (+2)
 - A character speaks the name of the missing kingdom aloud (+1, resets monthly)

At 4 segments: The ghost of the missing king begins appearing in dreams. At 8 segments: The missing kingdom manifests as a phantom realm for one night. The party may enter it — or be claimed by it. Resetting the clock requires a ritual at the Nine Kings’ Tomb, paying a weight in memory or blood.

- **The Ninth Breath (Highland):** Aeler miners believe that counting to nine in a mine summons the mountain’s attention. They count in eights, resetting after each set. Visitors who count to nine aloud may trigger a cave-in — or worse. Mechanically, any character who voluntarily counts to nine in a mine must test Resolve (DV 4) or mark 1 Fatigue as the mountain takes a breath. On a critical failure, the mountain takes a memory instead (lose 1 XP or forget a minor detail). This rule also applies in the lowlands when entering a stepwell or the Nine Kings’ Tomb.
- **Lease Clock [8] (Highland):** Tracks the political pressure around the treaty renewal. The clock ticks when the party assists or hinders a faction (Aeler, rajas, Admiralty, Covenant). At 4 segments: a faction threatens to walk out of negotiations. At 8: the lease is broken or renewed in the party’s favour (or against it). The party can reset the clock by brokering a concession.
- **Ancestral Honour (Reputation Track):** Each PC has an Ancestral Honour score from –3 (Heavy Burden) to +3 (Bearer of Light). Gain Burden (move toward negative) by: breaking a sworn oath, failing to protect a family member, disrespecting a temple. Gain Honour (move toward positive) by: keeping a difficult promise, restoring a forgotten genealogy, donating to a royal archive. Effects:
 - **+2 or +3 (Bearer of Light):** +1 Position in social encounters with nobles and priests. You may call in one minor family favour per session.
 - **–2 or –3 (Heavy Burden):** Market prices double for you. You may be challenged to a honour-duel (combat or legal contest). If you refuse, you lose 1 permanent Reputation tier.

- **Elephant Bonding (Lowland and Highland):** A character who spends a downtime scene with a war elephant may form a bond. The elephant gains a name and a personality. Once bonded, the elephant grants +1 die to the mahout's Command rolls in battle, but the mahout suffers -1 die to social rolls with elephant-hating factions (e.g., the Aeler counting houses, who fear the beasts). An elephant bonded to a character with high Ancestral Burden (negative) becomes melancholic and refuses to trample enemies of the missing kingdom.
- **Ritual Calendar (Lowland):** Temple dancers control the monsoon schedule. A party that earns the favour of a temple dancer (by protecting a shrine, funding a festival, or telling a true story) may ask for a "weather window": one journey leg where rain, fog, or heat does not apply. Using this favour ticks Ancestral Honour by -1 (the dancer's rivals will spread rumours that you owe a favour to the dancer). If the Ninth Kingdom Clock is at 4+, the weather window may instead open a path to the phantom kingdom.
- **Genealogy Forgery (Lowland):** A skilled forger can alter a king's family tree. This requires a 4-segment Forgery Clock (Wits + Craft, DV 4). If successful, the target king loses 2 Ancestral Honour (becomes more burdened) and the forger gains a permanent String against him. If discovered, the forger is exiled — or executed. A forgery that inserts a connection to the missing kingdom causes the Ninth Kingdom Clock to tick +2 immediately.
- **Elephant Community Share (Highland):** Instead of individual ownership, elephant caravans operate on a share system. A character who helps the caravan (clearing a pass, feeding a sick elephant, healing the mahout) gains a **Share Token**. Spend it to call on the caravan for a single favour: passage for a wagon, a day's fodder, or a warning about a rival. Share Tokens are not weight — they are reciprocity.
- **Breath-Bonds as Leverage (Highland):** Aeler engineers use breath-bonds to secure contracts. A character who holds a breath-bond can demand a renegotiation of tolls, quotas, or labour terms. The bond is not a weight — it is a recorded agreement that both parties benefit from keeping. Breaking a breath-bond does not incur a curse; it simply ends the trust, and the other party will never deal with you again.
- **The Ninth Caste (Nameless Spies, Lowland):** The ninth caste has no mark, no name, no legal existence. They are the king's enforcers, operating outside the law. A character who discovers a ninth caste spy may leverage that knowledge: gain +1 die on social rolls against that spy's master, but the spy becomes a recurring enemy. The ninth caste has its own obligation to the Hollow; they cannot die until it is paid.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Peacock's Eye** — The Witness. *The ruby that sees all false genealogies. It does not blink. It knows who owes.*
 - **The Iron Queen** — Mykkiel. *The law that binds the nine kingdoms, even when kings forget. Especially when they forget.*

- **The Monsoon Lord** — Khemesh. *The pressure that brings the rain — and the flood that follows. The flood claims its due.*
- **The Dancing Star** — The Traveler. *The rhythm that guides the dancer’s feet and the monsoon’s arrival. And the missing step.*
- **The Ninth Throne** — The Hollow. *The empty chair. The unpaid weight. The kingdom that never was.*
- **Thrain the Counter** — Mykkiel (Highland). *The divine auditor; every deed must balance.*
- **The Silent Bell** — The Sealed Gate (Highland). *The threshold that asks only that you stop at eight.*
- **The Forge Father** — Adur (Oath of Flame and Light). *The flame that tempers iron and burns lies.*
- **The Old Breath** — The Traveler (Highland). *The wind that carries caravans and counts their steps.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Nine Kings’ Tomb and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The tomb is said to contain a map to the Himadri temple where the amulet was sealed. A rival king may offer the party a noble title in exchange for the map. The map is tattooed on the inside of the Ninth King’s ghost. You will need to ask politely. The ghost charges a memory for each word of the map.
- **Covenant Judges and the Sidhi (Way of Silk):** High Judge Vasu has ruled on several cases involving Sidhi freedmen. He is known to be fair but harsh. A Sidhi port-master may ask the party to deliver a bribe — or a warning. The warning is written in disappearing ink. The ink is your own blood. The ninth word of the warning is the name of a Sidhi ship that carries cargo for the missing kingdom.
- **Elephant Herds and the Kuvani (Way of Silk):** The Kuvani have tried to buy war elephants from the Nine Kingdoms. The price is always refused — but a Kuvani remount master may offer a story worth the trade. The story must be about a horse that outran a king. The elephants will listen. They are not impressed. The ninth elephant in the herd is a ghost. It remembers the missing kingdom. It will carry anyone who tells it a true regret.
- **The Immortal Peacock and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The peacock is said to be the Hollow’s original form — before it learned to hunger. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings of peacock feathers at the Hollow’s gates to remind it of what it once was. The feathers are always accepted. The Hollow never thanks them. The ninth feather offered each year is returned, bloodied, to the Peacock Gardens.
- **The Ninth Seal Mine and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The demon sealed in the mine is a fragment of Varash the Unmaker. The Veiled Sisters want to free it

to use against the Covenant. The Breath-less want to re-seal it. The demon speaks in the voices of dead miners.

- **Iron Trade and the Ngomebe (Stone Men):** The iron from the Satrapies is used to forge rollers for the walking cities of Ngomebe. A disruption in the iron supply could stop a city mid-migration. The Mason-Kin have a permanent envoy at the Viceroy's hall.
- **The Blind Pilgrim and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The pilgrim is searching for a shrine that marks the Hollow's boundary in the high passes. Aelaerem hedge-keepers know the location but refuse to speak it. They say the shrine is a missing ninth step in the mountain's own counting song.

Dhaharan Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Peacock:** Crumble a crust before the throne. Ignore the first *Elephant Stampede* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Anklet:** Tie a silver bell to a dancer's anklet. Cancel *Temple Dance Cursed* or take -1 die on your next performance roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead king's name into the black water. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating a truce this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Covenant. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **The Ninth Step (Lowland):** When entering a court, take only eight steps. The ninth step is for the ghost of the missing king. If you take it, you will hear a whisper asking for a favour. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Bread to the Mine (Highland):** Crumble a crust into the tunnel mouth. Ignore the first *Cave-In* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Bell Rope (Highland):** Tie a knot in the rope of a shrine bell. Cancel *Ninth Echo* or take -1 die on your next stealth roll (the bell still rings, but muffled). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Iron (Highland):** Whisper a dead miner's name into an ingot. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with Aeler this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Viceroy. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **court chamberlains, temple priests, Aeler engineers, or raja's spies.**
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **elephant mahouts, bazaar merchants, mine guards, or toll-keepers.**

- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **rival spies, Covenant bailiffs, or mountain spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable audience with a king or viceroy**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.
- **Ninth Echo (Highland):** A whisper in the pass counts to eight. You feel a presence. The GM gains 1 SB to use on a future supernatural complication.
- **Ninth Step (Lowland):** A courtier counts your steps aloud. You stumble. The GM gains 1 SB to use on a future social complication.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local king's guard, Covenant bailiff, mine-captain, or toll-keeper becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **elephant stampede, riot, landslide, or thin air**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival kingdom's spy, bandit, or demon fragment arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.
- **Genealogy Taint (Lowland):** A rumour spreads that you are descended from the missing kingdom. Social rolls with nobles are Desperate for one scene.
- **Breath Shortage (Highland):** The air thins. All characters mark 1 Fatigue.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **elephant cavalry, temple guards, bandit crews, Aeler engineers, or raja's soldiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**pact broken/well poisoned/ghost accuses/mine seals/lease stone cracks/ninth echo spoken**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Ninth Kingdom Clock ticks +1:** The missing kingdom stirs. A ghost is seen. A temple dancer stumbles. A miner counts to nine.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Maharaja, High Judge Vasu, Ninth King's Ghost, Viceroy, or Demon from the Ninth Seal** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**throne hall collapses/well floods/peacock screams/mine collapses/bridge falls/lease stone shatters**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **The Missing Kingdom Manifests:** For one scene, the phantom realm overlaps with reality. All characters must test Resolve (DV 5) or become Lost (cannot be found until dawn).

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Dhahara (Court Law):** Peacock feathers shed without reason, a throne's ruby eyes follow a different person, a forgotten genealogy appears on a wall.
- **Dhahara (Elephant Law):** Elephants kneel unprompted, a tusk glows faintly, a mahout speaks a prophecy in his sleep.
- **Dhahara (Ancestral Honour):** A merchant refuses to meet your eyes, a child throws salt at your feet, a temple door closes as you approach, a ghost asks when you will pay what you owe.
- **Dhahara (Mine Law):** Iron veins glow faintly, the mountain groans, a breath-counter ticks backward.
- **Dhahara (Lease Politics):** The Viceroy's bell rings once for no reason, a raja's elephant kneels unprompted, a treaty scroll spontaneously combusts.
- **Dhahara (Pass Law):** Snow falls upward, the ninth echo repeats a different name each time, a bridge appears where there was only chasm.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth or Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud* (lowland) or *Thin Air* (highland).
- **Cut the Pact (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a peacock feather is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Cut the Toll (Presence + Sway, Highland):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a toll waiver is in your possession, +1 die.

- **Weather the Stampede (Body + Ride):** On a hit in *Elephant Stampede*, you pick who is trampled; on a miss, the GM does.
- **Weather the Cave-in (Body + Athletics, Highland):** On a hit in *Cave-In*, you pick who escapes first; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Throne, Well, Mine, and the Missing Ninth)

- **The Ninth King (Unburied)** — *Phases:* Tomb Robberies → Orchestrated Succession Crisis → Throne Coup. *Cracks:* return a stolen crown, expose a false genealogy, survive the Ninth King's Ghost. *Secret:* The Ninth King does not want to be restored to power — he wants his obligation to the Hollow paid. Pay it, and he will rest.
- **The Drought-Maker (Well Poisoner)** — *Phases:* Wells Drying → Procession of Empty Stepwells → Monsoon Baptism of a Dancer. *Cracks:* vial of pure well water, survivor testimony, the temple dancer's bells ringing true again. *Twist:* The Drought-Maker is a servant of the missing kingdom, sent to weaken the eight so that the ninth may return.
- **The Ghost Emperor of Rajagriha** — *Phases:* Imperial Echo → Legion of Shades → The Unfinished Throne. *Cracks:* speak a true kindness about his empire, return a broken pillar to its original place, promise to remember a name he has forgotten. *Price:* He will not pass on until someone takes his place as keeper of the missing kingdom's memory.
- **The Hollow's Accountant (Ninth Caste Master)** — *Phases:* Audit of the Living → Repossession → Foreclosure on a Kingdom. *Cracks:* prove that a weight has been paid twice, present a genealogy that shows the Hollow itself as a debtor, or offer a new missing kingdom to take the place of the old. *Warning:* The Accountant cannot be fought — only negotiated with. Its quill writes in reverse. Its ink is your blood.
- **The Breath-Eater (Nine Silence, Highland)** — *Phases:* Mines Collapsing → Orchestrated Cave-In → Pass Coup. *Cracks:* find a lost breath-counter, expose a false lease, survive a count of nine.
- **The Unsealed (Demon of the Ninth Seal, Highland)** — *Phases:* Whispers in the Mine → Procession of Cracking Timbers → Iron-Baptism of a Viceroy. *Cracks:* relic Covenant seal, survivor testimony, the mine's face weeping clear water.

Patronage & Power

Among the Dhaharan, power flows through genealogy, elephant herds, the honour of the court, and the crushing weight of ancestral obligation — and in the high passes, through iron, tea, and the lease. A king's authority rests on his dynasty's archive; a queen's on her marriage alliances; a temple dancer's on the rhythm of the monsoon; a viceroy's on the High King's seal and the loyalty of his engineers. The Peacock Throne is the centre, but the other eight kingdoms are not satellites — they are competitors. And the missing ninth is the weight that never stops compounding. In the north, the Aeler and Dhaharan have bled into the same stone, and the mountain remembers both.

For the GM: Power in Dhahara is measured in iron, buffalo, the thickness of a family's scroll collection, the number of forgotten promises in its bloodline, and the number of breaths a miner can hold. Patronage often takes the form of peacock feathers, iron gate passes, Covenant seals, royal decrees, breath-counters, and toll waivers — each tied to a specific kingdom, clan, court, or mine. To emphasise the honour-based strangeness and the uneasy Aeler-Dhaharan hybrid:

- Use the **Ancestral Honour Dial** as a visible track. Let players gain or lose Honour based on their actions in native courts. High Honour (positive) opens doors; low Honour (negative) closes them — and may bring the Hollow's accountants.
- Let the nine kingdoms be a web of shifting alliances and unpaid obligations. A favour from the Maharaja may be an insult to the Rani — and a weight to a third kingdom that must be balanced.
- Use the stepwells, elephant stables, throne halls, mines, bridges, and the Viceroy's hall as arenas for social contests, where a well-recited genealogy is a weapon, a broken promise is a declaration of war, and a count of eight is a threat.
- Track the **Ninth Kingdom Clock** as a slow-burn campaign timer. The party cannot stop it permanently — only delay it, redirect it, or prepare for the night when the missing kingdom returns. That night, the Hollow will collect. The question is who will pay.
- In the high passes, use the **Lease Clock** to mirror the politics of the lowlands. The renewal of the lease is a recurring pressure point; the party can tilt it toward Aeler, rajas, or a third party.
- Emphasise that the Aeler are **not conquerors** — they are lessees, bound by treaty. Their engineers and viceroys are in Dhaharan territory on Dhaharan sufferance, renewed every nine years. The rajas tolerate them because the iron trade is profitable and the passes are dangerous. But the lease can be broken — by a stone cracking, by a demon waking, by a king's whim.

In Dhahara, the peacock remembers every eye, the well shows every death, the mountain takes every ninth breath, and the missing kingdom waits. Its weight is never closed.

Chapter 4

The Himadri Foothills

The Roof of the World.

Govind shivers: *“The mountain does not speak in words. It speaks in the silence after a bell, the weight of a frozen lung, the taste of iron on the tongue at dusk. We Aeler do not conquer stone. We listen to it – and we remember what it forgets.”*

The Himadri foothills are the highest inhabited place in the known world. Here, the Aelerian mountains scrape the sky, and the air is so thin that each breath is a measured gift. The native Aeler of these peaks – called the High Aeler or the Karak-Aeler (“Stone-Breath People”) – are not the mercantile dwarves of the lowland holds. They are severe, cold, and ancient, their faces carved by wind and frost, their voices rarely raised above a whisper. They do not trade in breath-bonds for profit; they trade in survival. The humans of the Himadri – the High Folk, or Mi-tsang – are equally remote: a scattering of monastic villages, goat-herding clans, and hidden fortress-temples that have never paid tribute to any king. The demon sealed in the Ninth Seal Mine – a fragment of Varash the Unmaker – is not a legend. It is a fact. The seal is cracking. And the mountain is listening.

“Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one – a breath, a memory, a shadow.”

— Mine-Breath, who carries her grandfather’s bell

What do people eat for breakfast? Iron rations and tea – the rations arehardtack and dried meat, the tea brewed from leaves that grow only above the snow line. The leaves are harvested by the Vent-Prior’s apprentices. The lottery is a death sentence.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a pressure gauge. The eight pressures: Safe, Warning, Danger, Collapse, Flood, Fire, Seal, and the ninth – the pressure that means the mountain is breathing. The mountain’s breath is the miners’ death.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their bell. Every miner carries a breath-counter bell. A bell that rings too fast means running. A silent bell means dead. A bell that rings the ninth note means a demon.

What is the most common crime? Ore smuggling – but smuggling is a perquisite. The mine-captains take a cut called “the Vent-Prior’s fee.” The negotiation involves tea and threats.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Ninth Seal is not a seal. It is a door – a gate to a prison that holds something that should not be named. The keepers do not want to know what is inside.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the mountain. Bodies left in worked-out galleries. The mountain absorbs them. Its memory grows.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a breath – one of your own, counted and witnessed. Sealed in a brass capsule and placed in the Vent-Prior's ledger. The ledger is the court. The mountain's judgment is final.*

What is the most important festival? *The Counting of the Breath (winter solstice). Every miner's breath-counter is read aloud. Those with the lowest counts are promoted. Those with the highest are retired to a sealed gallery. The gallery is a tomb.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The demon in the Ninth Seal is not a demon. It is an Aeler – the first Vent-Prior, who volunteered to be sealed with the mountain's hunger. He is still alive. He has been counting his breaths for nine centuries. He has reached the ninth count. He is still counting.*

Integration Notes

The Himadri iron mines feed the forges of the Brass Coast and the walking cities of Ngomebe. Aeler breath-bonds are recognised by Covenant judges as valid contracts. The Ninth Seal demon is whispered about by Sihai monks (who have their own sealed archives) and by Breath-less agents (who believe it is a fragment of the same entity bound in the Kalrantha amulet). The Kalrantha amulet itself is said to have been forged in these mountains – a green glass shard that can still be found in the scree if you know where to look.

4.1 The Himadri Foothills — “The Roof of the World”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mountain does not negotiate. It waits. The ninth breath is a toll, not a gift.*

Khardung, Vent-Prior of the High Places (Elite): “The mountain does not speak in words. It speaks in the silence after a bell, the weight of a frozen lung, the taste of iron on the tongue at dusk. We Aeler do not conquer stone. We listen to it. And we remember what it forgets.”

Mine-Breath (Commoner): “I carry a bell that counts my breaths. Eight is safe. Nine is the mountain’s. My grandfather counted to nine once. The mountain took his shadow. He lived another thirty years, but he never cast a shadow again. The High Folk say the shadow still walks the passes, counting.”

Genre / Mood: High-altitude survival horror, animist dread, isolation, the weight of ancient oaths.

Starting Location: A wind-scoured pass where prayer flags made of frozen leather snap like bones. A dwarf in a patched iron coat tends a brass brazier. Beside her, a human in a grey wool cloak — face hidden by a veil of yak hair — holds a bell that does not ring. The dwarf speaks first: “The High Folk say the demon stirs in the deep. The passes are closing early. You have three breaths to declare your purpose, or the mountain will decide for you.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Himadri foothills are the highest inhabited place in the known world. Here, the Aelerian mountains scrape the sky, and the air is so thin that each breath is a measured gift. The native Aeler of these peaks — called the High Aeler or the *Karak-Aeler* (“Stone-Breath People”) — are not the mercantile dwarves of the lowland holds. They are severe, cold, and ancient, their faces carved by wind and frost, their voices rarely raised above a whisper. They do not trade in breath-bonds for profit; they trade in survival. A Karak-Aeler’s word is iron not because of law, but because the mountain has no patience for lies.

The humans of the Himadri are equally remote: a scattering of monastic villages, goat-herding clans, and hidden fortress-temples that have never paid tribute to any king. Outsiders call them the High Folk, or simply the *Mi-tsang* — the Hidden People. They speak a language of tones and silences, and they venerate spirits that live in glaciers, hot springs, and the bones of extinct beasts. Their lamas (called *Lopön*) keep scrolls that predate the Utaran Empire, written in a script that no Aeler can read. They do not trust the lowlands, and the lowlands have learned not to cross their passes without an invitation.

The Karak-Aeler and the High Folk share an uneasy peace, brokered centuries ago when the first iron was traded for the secret of the high passes. Today, the dwarves mine the frozen mountains for ore and rare earths, while the humans tend the yak herds and the shrines that keep the mountain spirits from waking. The Covenant has a small mission in the highest valley, but its priests are always on the edge of frostbite and despair. The demon sealed in the Ninth Seal Mine — a fragment of Varash the Unmaker — is not a legend. It is a fact. The seal is cracking. And the mountain is listening.

What you notice first: The silence. Not the absence of sound, but the weight of it — as if the mountain itself is holding its breath. The way every Aeler touches a brass bell at their belt before speaking of distances. The way the High Folk never look directly at the peaks, only at the ground, as if the sky holds something they are not meant to see.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count your breaths aloud in a mine or a high pass. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one — a breath, a memory, a shadow. The High Folk say that the shadow then walks the passes, counting others.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Peak

Power here is measured in altitude, in the number of passes you know, and in the respect the mountain shows you. The Karak-Aeler maintain the iron mines and the toll-bridges, but they do not rule the High Folk — they coexist with them. The High Folk’s lamas negotiate on behalf of the mountain spirits, and the dwarves have learned to listen. The Covenant’s seal on the Ninth Seal Mine is maintained by a single, half-mad priest who has not seen the sun in forty years. The demon whispers promises of warmth, of gold, of the lowlands’ green

fields. The miners cover their ears. The High Folk leave offerings of frozen butter tea at the seal's entrance. So far, it has held.

Prominent NPCs of the Himadri Foothills

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
—	Khardung	Stone-voiced	Vent-Prior of the High Places	Keep the mines open and the demon sealed. He has not slept in a heated room in forty years. He says warmth makes the mountain forget him.
—	Lopön Tenzin	High Folk lama of the Ice Shrine	Interpret the will of the mountain spirits	He has not spoken a word of Low Utaran in thirty years. He communicates through a novice who signs.
—	Mine-Captain Dolkhar	Karak-Aeler engineer	Extract enough ore to pay the mountain's toll	She lost three fingers to frostbite; she replaced them with iron picks. She never removes her gloves.
—	The Seal-Keeper (Nameless)	Covenant priest of the Ninth Seal	Keep the demon from waking, one day at a time	He has forgotten his own name. The seal remembers it for him. His eyes are rust-coloured.
—	Yak-Mother Pema	High Folk herder, keeper of the pass offerings	Ensure the mountain spirits do not close the high route	She knows every hidden spring and every avalanche chute. She will not guide outsiders — only sell them directions.

Names of the Himadri Foothills

Karak-Aeler names are short, harsh, with guttural stops and iron-hard consonants. High Folk names are softer, with flowing vowels and honorific prefixes.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	Karak-Aeler (Male)	Karak-Aeler (Female)	High Folk (Both)	Epithets
—	Khardung	Dolkhar	Tenzin	<i>Iron-Beard</i>
—	Borin	Thrain	Pema	<i>Stone-Breath</i>
—	Rurik	Korra	Lhamo	<i>the Unshadowed</i>
—	Halik	Svar	Namgyal	<i>Bell-Breaker</i>

(Mine/Shrine/Pass) Iron mine with a carved face that weeps rust; a High Folk shrine of stacked stones and frozen prayer flags; a pass where the air is so thin that even the crows turn back.

Spades — Places

2. **Iron Mine of the Crying Face** — A deep shaft with a carved face above the entrance. *The face weeps rust. The tears are iron oxide. The mountain is mourning its dead.* ‘[INDUSTRIAL]’
3. **The Ninth Seal Mine (Sealed)** — A tunnel mouth sealed with Covenant clay and iron bands. *The seal is warm. It glows faintly at night. The demon whispers through the cracks in a language that sounds like butter melting.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’
4. **Silent Pass** — A high mountain pass where no bird flies. *The air is too thin for sound. Arguments must be written in the snow. The snow does not lie.* ‘[WEATHER]’
5. **Bridge of Nine Echoes (Karak-Aeler)** — A rope bridge over a frozen chasm. *Each step echoes nine times. The ninth echo is always a whisper — the name of the next person to fall. Do not answer.* ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’
6. **Ice Shrine** — A cave temple where the High Folk leave offerings of butter tea and frozen barley. *The ice never melts, even when a fire is lit inside. The lamas say the mountain drinks the heat.* ‘[RITUAL]’
7. **Yak-Mother’s Camp** — A seasonal encampment of black wool tents, smelling of smoke and sour milk. *The yaks have names. They answer to them. Outsiders who guess a yak’s name correctly are offered tea. Those who guess wrong are offered the cold.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
8. **The Frozen Ledger (Vent-Prior’s Archive)** — A cave where breath-bonds are carved into slabs of permafrost. *The ice preserves the contracts. If a bond is broken, the slab cracks. The sound echoes through the mines for days.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
9. **High Folk Watchtower** — A stone spire on a ridge, manned by a silent figure in a grey cloak. *The watcher never sleeps. They signal with mirrors — one flash for safe, two for storm, three for demon-walk.* ‘[WATCH]’
10. **The Ninth Breath Shrine** — A small cairn where miners leave offerings of their own shadow-traces. *The offerings are not coin — they are memories written on strips of leather. The leather never rots. The memories are still warm.* ‘[RITUAL]’
- J **Abandoned Mine of the First Seal** — A collapsed tunnel where the demon first manifested. *The walls are coated in green glass — like the Kalrantha amulet. The glass sings at midnight. Those who listen too long forget their names.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **The Lopön’s Hermitage** — A tiny stone hut perched on a cliff, accessible only by a rope ladder. *The lama has not descended in nine years. His food is hauled up by a single, silent novice. The novice never speaks of what the lama sees.* ‘[MYSTERY]’

- K Karak-Aeler Forge (High)** — A smithy built into a volcanic vent, heated by the mountain's own warmth. *The forge has no chimney. The smoke is swallowed by the stone. The smiths say the mountain eats their impurities.* '[CRAFT]'
- A The First Keystone (Myth)** — A stone that never cracks, said to lie at the deepest point of the oldest mine. *It is the mountain's heart. Touch it, and the mountain will ask a question. Answer poorly, and the passes close forever. Answer well, and it may ask another.* '[LEGEND]'

(Dwarf/Lama/Herder) Karak-Aeler mine-captain with a bell and a level; High Folk lama with a veil of yak hair; yak-mother with a staff of frozen juniper.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Mine-Captain (Karak-Aeler)** — A dwarf with a brass bell and a level. She never counts her breaths aloud. *She has never lost a crew. She has also never smiled. The miners say her bell rings only for the dead.* '[AUTHORITY]'
3. **Lopön (High Folk Lama)** — A figure in grey wool, face hidden by a veil. They communicate through a novice who signs. *The lama's hands are stained black with iron from the offerings. They never touch the ground.* '[SPIRIT]'
4. **Yak-Mother Pema** — A weathered woman with a bone needle in her hair, always surrounded by yaks. *She knows every pass, every avalanche, every hidden spring. She will not guide you — but she will sell you directions for a story. The story must be true.* '[COMMUNITY]'
5. **The Seal-Keeper (Nameless)** — A Covenant priest in rust-stained robes, sitting by the Ninth Seal. *He has not eaten solid food in forty years. The seal's glow sustains him. He has forgotten his own name. The seal remembers it for him.* '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Vent-Prior Khardung** — A dwarf with a bell around his neck, his face cracked by frost. *The bell rings when he lies. It rings often. He is always lying about the ore quotas. The miners know. They work anyway.* '[AUTHORITY]'
7. **High Folk Watcher** — A silent figure in a watchtower, holding a brass mirror. *They have not spoken in nine years. They communicate with mirror flashes. One flash: safe. Two: storm. Three: demon-walk. Four has never been seen.* '[SCOUT]'
8. **Iron-Bound Miner** — A dwarf who sold a memory to the mountain for a higher quota. She can no longer recall her mother's face. *She works in the deepest galleries. The other miners leave offerings of silence when she passes.* '[DEBT]'
9. **High Folk Novice** — A young woman who speaks for the silent lama. Her hands are always wrapped in wool. *She has never spoken a word of her own. The lama speaks through her. She does not know if she is a vessel or a person.* '[MYSTIC]'

10. **Frozen Caravan Master** — A Dhaharan trader who braves the high passes for rare earths. *He has lost three fingers to frostbite. He keeps them in a jar as a warning. The jar is on the ninth shelf.* ‘[TRADE]’
- J **Ghost of the Landslide** — A figure in grey, seen only at dusk. It points at the pass. *It is pointing at a safe route — or a trap. No one has survived to find out. The ghost does not speak. It does not need to.* ‘[DEATH]’
- Q **Demon’s Whisper** — A voice heard in the Ninth Seal Mine. It offers deals. *“A year of warmth for a single memory. A century of life for a death. The seal is cold. I am patient.” The voice sounds like someone you loved.* ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[FEAR]’
- K **The First Miner (Legend)** — A skeleton holding a tuning fork, sitting at the First Keystone. *If you take the tuning fork, you become the mountain’s new voice. You will never leave the depths. The miners will hear you sing. They will not thank you.* ‘[LEGEND]’
- A **Ice-Lama (Myth)** — A High Folk saint who froze to death in meditation. Her body did not decay. *She sits in a cave of blue ice. If you bring her a true regret, she will warm your hands for a moment. The warmth lasts a lifetime.* ‘[SAINT]’

(Cold/Seal/Spirit) A sudden drop in temperature — all actions Desperate; the Ninth Seal cracks — the demon whispers promises; a mountain spirit demands an offering of silence.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Whiteout** — A sudden blizzard erases all tracks. Navigation is impossible. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby. The wind sounds like a name being called. Your name.*
3. **Landslide** — The pass is blocked. The alternative route is three days longer. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The landslide was deliberate — a rival caravan master wants to delay you. His camels are ahead. His guilt is written in the mud.*
4. **Ninth Echo Heard** — Someone on the Bridge of Nine Echoes counts the echoes. The ninth echo speaks a name. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The name is the speaker’s. They faint. The bridge remembers. The name is now a toll. The bridge will collect.*
5. **Breath Shortage** — At high altitude, the party struggles. Mark Fatigue 1 per scene. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *Acclimatisation requires a rest day. The rest day will cost a toll. The toll is a breath-bond. The mountain is watching.*
6. **Seal Cracking** — The Ninth Seal groans. The demon’s whisper grows louder. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *A character hears their own voice offering a deal. The price is a memory of a warm place. Refuse, and the cold deepens.*

7. **Yak Stampede** — A herd of startled yaks thunders through the camp. ‘[DISASTER]’
They are not angry. They are fleeing something worse. The mist behind them has a shape. The shape is counting.
8. **Covenant Audit** — The Seal-Keeper demands to inspect the party’s cargo. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The cargo includes a relic from the Red Desert — a piece of green glass. It is humming. The Seal-Keeper’s eyes are weeping rust.*
9. **High Folk Taboo Broken** — A party member speaks a forbidden name or forgets to offer butter tea at a shrine. ‘[SPIRIT]’ *The mountain spirits are offended. The next pass they cross will be twice as long. The snow will fall upward.*
10. **Demon-Touched Miner** — A miner who made a bargain with the demon escapes from the deep galleries. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Their eyes are green glass. Their shadow has horns. They do not attack — they ask: “Where is the ninth bone?”*
- J **Vent-Prior’s Summons** — Khardung demands the party attend him. He offers a deal: find a saboteur in exchange for warm shelter. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[POLITICS]’
The saboteur is his own clerk. The clerk is his daughter. She is trying to open the Ninth Seal. She wants to free the demon. She thinks it will warm the mines.
- Q **The Silent Pass’s Cold (Supernatural)** — The temperature drops so low that metal sticks to skin. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *The cold is a spirit. It wants a breath-bond. It will accept a story. The story must be about fire. It has never heard a good one.*
- K **Demon Wakes** — The Ninth Seal cracks open. A shadow escapes. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *It possesses the nearest High Folk novice. The novice’s eyes turn to green glass. She speaks in the lama’s voice: “The mountain is hungry. Feed it.”*
- A **First Keystone Quakes** — The mountain’s heart trembles. The passes close. The mines collapse. The demon is free. ‘[APOCALYPSE]’ *The party has one day to re-seal the demon or flee. The Vent-Prior is weeping. The Seal-Keeper is dead. The mountain is counting.*

(Bell/Ingot/Prayer) Aeler breath-counter (silver bell, wear to count breaths safely); iron ingot stamped with a mountain rune; a High Folk prayer flag that never tears.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Aeler Breath-Counter (Silver Bell)** — Wear it to count your breaths safely in high altitude. The bell rings when you reach eight. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *Stop at eight. The ninth breath is the mountain’s. The bell also rings when a demon is near. The tone is flat.*

3. **Iron Ingot (Mountain-Stamped)** — A bar of high-grade iron, stamped with a rune that means “witness.” Worth 1 Measure. ‘[TRADE]’ *The rune glows when a lie is spoken nearby. It does not judge the lie — it merely records.*
 4. **High Folk Prayer Flag** — A square of undyed wool, marked with a symbol of a closed eye. ‘[PROTECTION]’ *Hang it at your camp, and the mountain spirits will not trouble you for one night. The flag must be burned at dawn. The smoke carries your thanks.*
 5. **Seal-Keeper’s Blessing (Clay Amulet)** — A lump of clay from the Ninth Seal’s entrance. ‘[JUSTICE]’ ‘[MAGIC]’ *Press it to a lock or a threshold, and the demon’s attention is drawn elsewhere for one hour. The amulet crumbles after use. The demon will remember.*
 6. **Yak-Mother’s Route (Leather Map)** — A scrap of leather marked with charcoal lines. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The map shows a safe route through the high passes — but only if you follow it exactly. If you stray, the map rewrites itself. The new route leads to a crevasse.*
 7. **Lopön’s Silence (Wool Cord)** — A braided cord that the lama wore around his wrist. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[SPIRIT]’ *Tie it around your own wrist. For one scene, you are invisible to mountain spirits. You also cannot speak. The silence is the price.*
 8. **Vent-Prior’s Letter of Introduction (Frozen Slate)** — A slate tablet that must be held against warm skin to read. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Grants access to any Karak-Aeler mining hold. The slate is cold. It grows colder when the holder lies.*
 9. **Demon’s Nail (Iron Splinter)** — A piece of the Ninth Seal’s timber. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *Touch it to a lock; the lock opens. The lock also screams. The scream alerts the demon. The nail crumbles after one use. The demon knows your face now.*
 10. **Ice-Lama’s Blessing (Frozen Tear)** — A drop of water that never melts, said to be the saint’s tear. ‘[HEALING]’ *Drink it to remove one level of Harm caused by cold or exhaustion. The tear tastes of salt and memory.*
- J **The Ninth Echo’s Whisper (Slate)** — A piece of slate carved with the ninth echo’s words. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *Play it to silence a foe. The foe hears their own name and freezes for one exchange. The slate then crumbles. The echo is now silent. The bridge has one fewer whisper.*
- Q **First Keystone’s Echo (Tuning Fork)** — A tuning fork that rings with the mountain’s voice. ‘[LEGEND]’ *Strike it, and the mountain will answer one question — but the answer is always a riddle, and the riddles are always about debts.*
- K **High Folk Novice’s Memory (Bone Needle)** — A needle that the novice used to sew her silence. ‘[SECRET]’ *Thread it with a strand of your own hair and sew a wound closed. The wound heals, but you forget why you received it. The needle remembers.*

A Vent-Prior's Forgiveness (Iron Token) — A token that grants pardon for any crime in the Himadri. '[AUTHORITY]' *The pardon is conditional. The condition is a secret mission: re-seal the demon permanently. The Vent-Prior's bell will not ring for this lie.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (bells, ingots, prayers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **mountain-omens**—iron that weeps rust, bells that ring without clappers, a pass that closes behind you, a whisper that sounds like your own breath, a shadow that walks without a body.

Additional Features (High Altitude Mechanics)

- **Breath-Counting:** In high passes (above 4,000 metres), characters must mark Fatigue for every hour of exertion. A character who deliberately paces their breathing (making a Resolve test, DV 3) can reduce the Fatigue cost by 1. Counting aloud to nine in any context triggers a *Mountain's Attention* roll (Spirit + Resolve, DV 4). On failure, the mountain takes something: 1 Fatigue, a minor memory (erase a fact), or a shadow (the character casts no reflection until they leave the high passes).
- **The Ninth Seal Clock [8]:** The Covenant seal on the demon mine has a hidden clock that ticks when the demon whispers, when someone takes iron from the sealed tunnel, or when a breath-bond is broken nearby. When the clock fills, the seal cracks. The party can reset the clock by reinforcing the seal with a new Covenant rite (costs a memory) or by feeding the demon a story (costs a truth). The demon prefers stories about betrayal. It pays attention to those.
- **Mountain Offerings:** The High Folk believe that the mountain must be fed with offerings of silence, memory, or warmth. A character who leaves an offering (a pinch of salt, a whispered secret, a lock of hair) at a shrine or a cairn may roll Spirit + Lore (DV 3). On success, the next weather hazard in that pass is downgraded (blizzard to snow, ice to frost). On failure, the offering is rejected — the character gains the *Marked by the Mountain* condition (the next environmental complication is automatically Desperate).
- **High Folk Taboos:** The High Folk have many taboos: never point at a peak, never speak the name of a dead person in a pass, never refuse a cup of butter tea, never step over a prayer flag. Breaking a taboo in front of a High Folk witness causes the witness to fall silent and refuse to help. The GM may spend 1 SB to have a broken taboo attract the attention of a mountain spirit (a complication from the *Clubs* table).

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **Adur the Forge-Father** — Oath of Flame and Light. *The fire in the smelter, the heat that tempers iron and oaths.*
- **Hemrir the Wanderer** — The Sealed Gate. *The keeper of thresholds; his shrines are bridge-posts and tunnel mouths.*
- **The Breath-Eater** — Khemesh. *The pressure in the deep; the silence that follows a cave-in.*
- **The Ice-Lama** — The Pale Shepherd. *The saint who froze to death; she guides travellers through whiteouts.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Ninth Seal and the Kalrantha Amulet (Dhahara):** The demon in the sealed mine is a fragment of Varash the Unmaker, the same entity trapped in the Kalrantha amulet. The Veiled Sisters want to free this fragment to use against the Covenant. The Breath-less want to re-seal it permanently. The demon wants to be whole. It offers favours to anyone who brings it a shard of green glass.
- **Iron Trade and the Ngomebe Stone Men:** The iron from the Himadri mines is shipped to Ngomebe to forge rollers for the walking cities. A disruption in the iron supply could stop a city mid-migration. The Ngomebe Mason-Kin have a permanent envoy at the Vent-Prior's hall. The envoy is a woman who speaks only in stone-songs. She has never smiled.
- **Breath-Bonds and the Covenant (Mykkiel):** The Covenant recognises Aeler breath-bonds as legally binding, but only if witnessed by a judge. The Seal-Keeper is the only Covenant authority in the high passes. He has not witnessed a new bond in twenty years. He says the mountain remembers all debts anyway.
- **The Silent Pass and the Hollow (Eastern Realms):** The Silent Pass is a known threshold where the Hollow's attention is thin. Aelaerem hedge-keepers leave offerings of salt at the pass entrance to keep the Oath-Keepers from following caravans. The salt must be from the pans of the Silent Widows. Any other salt will attract them. The Hedge-Keepers will not explain why. They say the salt knows.

Himadri Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Mine:** Crumble a crust into the tunnel mouth. Ignore the first *Whiteout* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Bell Rope:** Tie a knot in the rope of the shrine bell. Cancel *Ninth Echo* or take -1 die on your next stealth roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Iron:** Whisper a dead miner's name into an ingot. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with Karak-Aeler this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Vent-Prior. '[SUPERSTITION]'

- **Butter to the Shrine:** Leave a lump of yak butter at a cairn. The next time you cross a pass, the mountain will not take your shadow. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **Karak-Aeler mine-captains** or **High Folk lamas**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watchers** or **yak-herders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **mountain spirits** or **demon-touched miners**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favourable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local mine-captain** or **seal-keeper** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **whiteout** or **crevasse field**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **demon-touched miner** or a **territorial snow cat** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Karak-Aeler miners**, **High Folk watchers**, or **demon fragments** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **seal cracks** / **ninth echo spoken** / **whiteout worsens**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1**/**Harm 1**/**Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Vent-Prior, Lopön, or Demon from the Ninth Seal** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **mine collapses / bridge falls / ice shrine cracks.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears / blessing lost / curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Himadri (High Altitude):** Breath-counters tick backward, snow falls upward, the air tastes of copper.
- **Himadri (Demon Seal):** The Ninth Seal's glow intensifies, demon whispers become audible, a crack appears in the clay.
- **Himadri (High Folk):** A prayer flag tears, a yak lows at midnight, a lama's bell rings without being struck.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Frostbite*.
- **Cut the Toll (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a toll waiver is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Whiteout (Resolve + Athletics):** On a hit in *Whiteout*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Breath & Demon)

- **The Breath-Eater (Nine Silences)** — *Phases:* Mines Collapsing → Orchestrated Breath-Bond Break → Pass Coup. *Cracks:* find a lost breath-counter, expose a false keystone, survive a count of nine.
- **The Unsealed (Demon of the Ninth Seal)** — *Phases:* Whispers in the Mine → Procession of Cracking Seals → Iron-Baptism of a Vent-Prior. *Cracks:* relic Covenant seal, survivor testimony, the mine's face weeping clear water.

- **The Ice-Lama's Waking (High Folk Saint)** — *Phases*: Frozen Tears → The Cold Remembers → The Ninth Breath Spoken. *Cracks*: return a stolen prayer flag, speak a true regret at her feet, survive a night in her cave without fire.

Patronage & Power

In the Himadri foothills, power flows through breath, silence, and the weight of the mountain's attention. The Karak-Aeler hold the mines and the forges, but they do not rule the High Folk — they coexist with them, bound by ancient compacts sealed in frozen iron. The High Folk's lamas speak for the mountain spirits, and the spirits are not kind. The Covenant's seal on the Ninth Seal Mine is a reminder of what happens when the mountain is not respected. The demon whispers. The mountain listens. And the passes remember every breath taken in them.

For the GM: Power in the Himadri is measured in altitude, in the number of breaths you can hold, and in the stories the mountain chooses to remember. Patronage often takes the form of breath-counters, iron ingots, or prayer flags — each tied to a specific pass, a specific spirit, a specific debt. To emphasise the harsh, remote character:

- Make **breath-counting** a constant tension: characters must manage their Fatigue carefully. The mountain punishes haste.
- Let the **Ninth Seal Clock** be a visible campaign front. The party's actions tick the clock; when it fills, the demon manifests. The demon does not fight — it negotiates. It offers warmth, iron, safe passage. It asks for small betrayals. The High Folk say that the demon's bargains always leave a frost on the heart.
- Use the **High Folk taboos** to create social tension. Breaking a taboo is not a crime — it is an insult to the mountain. The High Folk will not explain the taboos beforehand; they expect visitors to watch and learn. A character who makes an offering without being asked gains a small boon. A character who refuses an offering gains the mountain's attention.

In the Himadri, the mountain forgets nothing — and the ninth breath is always waiting.

Appendix A

Trade & Tariffs of Dhahara

The Spice Auction (Brass Coast)

Pepper, cardamom, and cinnamon are sold by candle auction: a one-inch candle is lit; bids are taken while it burns. When the flame gutters, the last bid wins. A failed Insight roll may mean you bid on a lot of inferior grade – the auctioneer’s smile is not a promise.

Iron Quotas (Nine Kingdomss)

Each kingdom has an annual iron quota owed to the Aeler viceroyalty. Quotas are paid in ingots stamped with the viceroy’s mark. Smuggling unstamped iron is a capital offence – the forges of the Brass Coast pay a premium for “unregistered” metal, but the Aeler breath-wardens can smell the difference.

Lighthouse Charters (Sidhi) as Currency

On the Brass Coast, a Sidhi lighthouse charter is accepted as legal tender for port fees, and a Kuvani remount master may honour it as proof of credit. The Fhara water-clerks are more suspicious – they weigh the wax seal against a water-share tablet.

Monsoon Trade Winds

From spring to autumn, the monsoon winds blow from the west, carrying Taharkan coffee and Ayokhan spices to Dhaharan ports. In winter, the winds reverse, carrying Dhaharan iron and brass east to Sihai and beyond. A captain who misses the window must pay a “wind toll” to the harbour master – or wait six months.

Appendix B

Elephants & Siege Engines

War elephants are not mere beasts; they are living siege towers. A fully armoured elephant can carry a howdah with archers, smash through wooden gates, and trample infantry lines.

Elephant Stats (Tier III)

- **Harm:** 5 (stomp or tusk), **Fatigue:** Body 5
- **Traits:** *Trample* – when moving through Close range, each enemy must test Body + Athletics (DV 3) or take Harm 2 (crushing). *Fear of Fire* – if targeted by a fire effect, the elephant must test Resolve (DV 4) or panic (stampede, uncontrolled).
- **Mahout Bond:** An elephant bonded to a mahout gains +1 die to resist fear. The mahout can spend a Boon to reroll the elephant's failed Resolve test.

Elephant Talents (for PCs)

- **Mahout's Whistle (2 XP)** – Once per scene, call your elephant to your side as a Move action.
- **Howdah Archer (4 XP)** – When firing from a moving elephant, ranged attacks suffer no Position penalty.
- **Tuskbreaker (6 XP)** – Your elephant's trample attack ignores 1 point of armor.

Appendix C

The Ninth Seal and the Kalrantha Amulet

The Demon in the Mine

Deep beneath the Himadri foothills, sealed by Covenant wax and Aeler iron, lies a fragment of **Varash the Unmaker** – a being of cosmic indifference that fed on the civilisation that turned the Red Desert to glass. It does not rage. It whispers. It offers bargains.

Whispers of the Seal (d6)

When the party approaches the Ninth Seal or a fragment of the amulet, roll or choose a whisper:

1. *“The seal was placed by a coward. He is still alive. Bring me his name, and I will give you a key that opens any lock – once.”*
2. *“You carry a secret. I can hear it. Shall I keep it, or shall I tell the one who matters most?”*
3. *“The Hollow and I are cousins. I taught it to count. It taught me to wait. Count to nine. I will show you the way out – but the way out leads through your own grave.”*
4. *“The Vent-Prior knows why the seal cracks. Ask him why he never counts his breaths aloud. He sealed me because he was afraid of what I would ask him to remember.”*
5. *“The Kalrantha amulet is a fragment of me. Bring it here. I will make you whole. I will give you certainty – the absolute knowledge that every choice you make is the right one. (The whisper laughs.) It always was, wasn’t it? You just didn’t know.”*
6. *“You are already dreaming this. When you wake, you will not remember me. But I will remember you. I will be waiting in the space between your heartbeats.”*

The Kalrantha Amulet

A shard of green glass set in a brass frame. It is said to grant a wish – but the wish always has a hidden clause. The Veiled Sisters want it to control the demon. The Breath-less want to destroy it. The Covenant wants to seal it again. And the rajas of the Nine Kingdomss want to use it to settle old feuds.

Mechanics (GM only)

The amulet is not a combat item. It is a plot device. Possessing it advances a **Kalrantha's Attention** clock [8]. When the clock fills, the demon manifests as a Tier IV adversary – not to fight, but to bargain. The price is always a memory, a name, or a promise.

Integration with the Way of Silk and Eastern Realms

- **Taharka and Ayokha (Monsoon Trade):** The amulet is said to have been carried east by a spice caravan that never reached its destination. Its trail goes cold in the Ayokhan highlands. A monsoon captain may have seen its green glow in a storm.
- **Sihai (Eastern Realms):** The Lethai-thora archives contain a scroll that describes the amulet's creation – written by a mad emperor who believed he could bind a demon to secure his Mandate. The scroll is sealed with nine silk cords. The ninth cord has never been cut.
- **The Brass Coast (Sidhi diaspora):** A Sidhi freedman claims her grandmother escaped from an Ashaani slave ship carrying the amulet. She threw it into the sea. The sea threw it back. It is now in the vault of a lighthouse judge, who uses it to blackmail the Admiralty.

Epilogue: The Ninth Lease

The lease is renewed every nine years. The iron quotas are adjusted. The spice auctions close at midnight. The demon whispers, and the mountain listens.

I have written eight scrolls for this book. The ninth is a lease – a contract between the Aeler viceroy and the raja of Kalinga, signed in blood and stamped with a bell that has no clapper. It expires next spring. I do not know if it will be renewed.

The road is south. The ink is fresh. The ninth seal is still warm.

— *Viceroy's Scribe Govind, at the weigh-house in Sarvistan, under a lamp that has just flickered for the eighth time*

"The elephant remembers. The mountain forgets. The demon waits. Choose your lease carefully."

— Dusana of the Raven Road (marginal note, found in a Pereshi fire-temple)

Colophon

This book was written on paper that had been a cargo manifest, a love letter, and a bandage. The ink is lampblack cut with salt water and the ash of a burnt confession. The binding is grey cord tied with nine knots. The ninth knot is not cut.

Govind composed the preface in a weigh-house while an Aeler breath-warden counted his exhalations. The almanacs were gathered from merchants, miners, and the occasional honest raja. The generator tables were tested in the field – meaning he ran them while a spice auctioneer took bids.

If you find yourself in Dhahara and a viceroy's scribe offers you a stamped receipt, accept it. If they offer you a lease, read the fine print. The ninth clause is always the one that kills you.

The elephant remembers. The mountain forgets. The demon waits.